ENGLISH FOR WORK / INTERNATIONAL MANAGERS

# Cross-Cultural Leadership English

Clear decisions. Constructive disagreement.
Trusted teams.



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Eight practical lessons. Eleven extended conversations.
Vocabulary, phrase banks, guided speaking, and explained answers.

Revised 2026 edition / Upper-intermediate to advanced

# Your route through the book


## 01 Check meaning before assuming agreement, page 4

Clarify scope, distinguish acknowledgment from approval, and confirm conditions.

## 02 Challenge ideas respectfully, page 13

Probe evidence, make a concession without surrendering the decision, and set a conduct boundary.

## 03 Make authority and participation clear, page 23

Define decision rights, invite recommendations, and delegate within explicit limits.

## 04 Negotiate realistic commitments, page 32

Offer bounded alternatives, use conditional commitments, and distinguish a forecast from a promise.

## 05 Include every voice in a meeting, page 42

Manage turn-taking, interrupt constructively, paraphrase accurately, and close a hybrid meeting.

## 06 Give specific, useful feedback, page 51

Describe behavior, explain operational impact, ask about causes, and agree a measurable next step.

## 07 Coordinate across offices, page 61

Negotiate a reporting interface, translate local constraints, and define exceptions without weakening oversight.

## 08 Repair misunderstandings and build trust, page 70

Acknowledge a specific impact, separate intent from effect, repair the record, and agree a verifiable change.

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Suggested study range: B2-C1. The core language is followed by more demanding precision and transfer work. This is an editorial study range, not a certified proficiency assessment.

# Direct is not the same as hostile.

"I don't buy that estimate" can be an invitation to test a proposal, not a statement of personal dislike. But you cannot reliably infer intent from directness alone. Ask for the evidence, watch the response, and distinguish a sharp challenge from personal contempt.

## Challenge the claim

"Which assumption is wrong?" keeps the discussion on something that can be checked. Accepting one criticism does not require abandoning the whole proposal.

## Set a behavioral boundary

"Keep the criticism on the estimate, not the people." A colleague's stated good intention does not erase an insult or repeated interruption.

## Check the local rule

First names, humor, and informal meetings do not tell you who can approve spending. Ask which decisions are yours and which need approval.

## Make room for a different pace

Some colleagues think aloud; others want time to read before speaking. Use a pre-read, a clear speaking order, and a later input route rather than equating speed with competence.

## Separate rapport from commitment

A friendly "sounds good" can support a direction without accepting a deadline. Confirm the deliverable, owner, condition, and time.

## Name what a deadline means

"Friday" may refer to different time zones or different versions of a report. State the clock time, location, and whether the figures are provisional or verified.

> **People vary within every workplace.**
>
> Nationality is not a personality test. Role, power, language confidence, professional training, and company norms also shape an exchange. Do not normalize threats, discrimination, or intimidation as a cultural style; use appropriate workplace support and reporting routes.

Research background: collaborative meaning-making [1], feedback about behavior and impact [2], and psychological safety in teams [3]. These are not rules predicting an individual's intent.

LESSON 01 / CHECK MEANING BEFORE ASSUMING AGREEMENT

# A Read the situation

Clarify scope, distinguish acknowledgment from approval, and confirm conditions.

**Launch tracker / Wednesday, 11:00 a.m.**

| ITEM | CURRENT RECORD |
|---|---|
| **Launch date** | Monday, proposed |
| **Trained staff** | 6 confirmed; 8 required |
| **Friday training** | 2 places booked; completion pending |
| **Decision owner** | Aiko, after Jordan reports the staffing check |

People: Aiko, International branch manager; Jordan, US-based operations lead.

## Read the record

Choose one answer per question using the facts above.

**1. Which statement can Aiko enter as confirmed now?**

**A.** Monday is approved subject to training.
**B.** Jordan has cleared the launch date.
**C.** Six people have completed training.
**D.** Eight people have places on Friday.

**2. Which next step preserves the decision boundary?**

**A.** Both trainees confirm and release the plan.
**B.** Jordan checks staffing and authorizes Monday.
**C.** Jordan checks staffing; Aiko decides afterward.
**D.** Aiko authorizes now and checks Friday.

**3. Jordan says, "The approach is fine." Which follow-up resolves its scope?**

**A.** Can I tell the team you are fully aligned?
**B.** Does that include Monday, or just the sequence?
**C.** Shall I record approval and add your staffing note?
**D.** Would a different date make you more comfortable?

Answers and explanations, page 89

# B Vocabulary in use

**CORE TERMS**

### acknowledgment
A signal that a message has been received or understood.

*acknowledge receipt*

### authorization
Permission from someone entitled to approve an action.

*obtain authorization*

### provisional
Not final; subject to a stated check or decision.

*provisional launch date*

### read-back
A spoken restatement used to check the shared record.

*give a read-back*

### scope
The limits of what a statement or agreement covers.

*clarify the scope*

### go/no-go decision
A decision to proceed or stop at a defined checkpoint.

*make a go/no-go decision*

### endorsement
An expression of support for a proposal or position.

*endorse a proposal*

### reservation
A concern that limits or qualifies support.

*express a reservation*

### dependency
Something that must happen for another action to proceed.

*resolve a dependency*

### sign-off
A formal or agreed approval step.

*get final sign-off*

### conditional agreement
Support that applies only if a requirement is met.

*record conditional agreement*

### green light
Informal permission to proceed, not merely positive feedback.

*give the green light*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**authorization** au-thor-i-ZA-tion

We have support for the plan, but no authorization to launch.

Support is not permission.

**provisional** pro-VI-sion-al

Treat Monday as provisional until Friday's check.

Provisional is not confirmed.

# B Precision and professional shorthand

**EXTEND YOUR RANGE**

### clarification

Additional detail that resolves an unclear meaning.

*seek clarification*

### pending

Waiting for an event, result, or decision.

*approval pending review*

### assumption

Something treated as true before it has been established.

*test an assumption*

### implicit

Suggested or understood without being stated directly.

*avoid relying on implicit consent*

### tentative

Not firmly settled and still open to change.

*set a tentative date*

### discrepancy

A difference between accounts or records that should match.

*resolve a discrepancy*

### alignment

A shared understanding or compatible direction; not necessarily formal approval.

*check alignment on the date*

### prerequisite

A requirement that must be met before another action.

*satisfy a prerequisite*

### explicit

Stated directly rather than left for the listener to infer.

*obtain explicit approval*

### qualification

A condition or limitation attached to a statement.

*add a qualification*

### supersede

Replace an earlier record, instruction, or decision.

*supersede the earlier minutes*

### in principle

At the level of the general idea, with details still unresolved.

*agree in principle*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**supersede** su-per-SEDE

This note supersedes the earlier minutes.

Supersede replaces a record; supplement adds to it.

**endorsement** en-DORSE-ment

Jordan endorsed the approach, not the date.

Name exactly what is endorsed.

# C Phrases that move the work forward

**Specify the reference**

When you say "fine," are you referring to the date or the overall approach?

**State the condition**

My support is conditional on having eight trained people.

**Preserve uncertainty**

That remains provisional until we complete the staffing check.

**Read back the agreement**

Let me read that back so we have the same decision record.

**Expose an assumption**

I may be reading more into that than you intended.

**Check the reference**

By "ready," do you mean trained, scheduled, or available for the first shift?

**Identify the missing evidence**

What evidence would let us change the status from pending to confirmed?

**Replace an inaccurate record**

This note supersedes the earlier statement that the date was final.

**Separate two meanings**

I heard support for the approach, not approval of the date.

**Check a commitment**

Can I record that as a commitment, or is it still a possibility?

**Make an indirect question**

Could you confirm whether the additional training is complete?

**Close the loop**

I will send the revised record and ask you to confirm it.

**Limit general agreement**

We agree in principle; the staffing condition is still open.

**Separate response and decision**

Please acknowledge receipt separately from confirming approval.

**Qualify a date**

Monday is our working date, subject to the Friday staffing check.

**Check the whole condition**

Is there any condition missing from that summary?

## Same purpose, different register

**To a colleague:** So the approach works; Monday is still open?
**In a decision record:** The approach is supported. Launch authorization remains pending.

**Clarifying politely:** I may have read too much into "fine."
**Confirming formally:** Please confirm whether your agreement includes the proposed date.

# D Choose the response that fits

Choose one response for each situation. Preserve the facts, the decision boundary, and the purpose of the exchange.

**1. Choose a correction to minutes that wrongly say "Monday approved."**

**A.** Monday remains proposed; Aiko will decide after Friday's staffing check.
**B.** Monday remains supported; the staffing check will follow the launch.
**C.** Monday remains likely; the team will proceed unless someone objects.
**D.** Monday remains approved; Jordan will add Friday's staffing figures.

**2. Which sentence distinguishes receipt from approval?**

**A.** I have seen the plan; go ahead with the proposed date.
**B.** I have read the plan; I have not authorized the date.
**C.** I have accepted the plan; the date is now in place.
**D.** I have read the plan; please regard the date as settled.

**3. Two training places are booked. What can the update say?**

**A.** Both people are available; training will confirm the date.
**B.** Both people are confirmed; their assessment will follow later.
**C.** Both places are booked; completion still needs confirmation.
**D.** Both people are ready; their training is scheduled Friday.

**4. Aiko wants a final check without making Jordan defend his intentions. Choose her line.**

**A.** What condition is missing from that summary?
**B.** Are you committed enough to make Monday happen?
**C.** Why did you agree if you had a reservation?
**D.** Can we leave your concern out until Friday?

Answers and explanations, page 89

> **One useful distinction**
>
> Acknowledgment confirms that a message was received or understood. Endorsement expresses support. Authorization permits action. Ask which of these the speaker is giving; do not record one as another.

# E Conversation

## When "fine" is not a green light

A branch launch review, followed by a short clarification meeting.

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once; some entries contain several words.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

reservation / prerequisite / give the green light / go/no-go decision / read-back / provisional / supersede / authorization / in principle / acknowledgment

01 **Aiko:** Before I send these minutes, can we check one line? I wrote "Monday launch approved." You said the plan was fine yesterday.

02 **Jordan:** The sequence was fine. I still had a [1] _____ about staffing. I thought I mentioned that before we moved on.

03 **Aiko:** You did mention training. I took that as an update, not a condition. That was my mistake.

04 **Jordan:** We have six people trained. We need eight. Two more are booked for Friday, but booking them isn't the same as having them ready.

05 **Aiko:** Right. So Monday stays [2] _____. I'll remove "approved" from the minutes.

06 **Jordan:** Thanks. I don't want the team to cancel anything yet, either. Monday could still work.

07 **Aiko:** Then I'll say we agree [3] _____ on the approach. The date remains open until Friday.

08 **Jordan:** That captures it. Who is going to tell the customer team? They've already asked me whether to send the launch notice.

09 **Aiko:** I will. Preparing the notice is fine; sending it needs my [4] _____. We haven't reached that point.

10 **Jordan:** Good. I can give you the training results Friday afternoon. Do you need anything beyond the completion list?

Conversation continues on the next page.

# When "fine" is not a green light

## CONVERSATION / CONTINUED

11 **Aiko:** Yes, please check that all eight are available for the first shift. Training is a [5] _____, not the entire readiness check.

12 **Jordan:** Understood. I'll confirm completion and first-shift availability. If one person doesn't finish, I'll flag that rather than count the booking.

13 **Aiko:** Please do. I'd rather have a clear [6] _____ than leave everyone interpreting "probably."

14 **Jordan:** Agreed. Could you copy me on the corrected minutes? People may still be looking at the first version.

15 **Aiko:** Yes. The new note will [7] _____ the earlier one. I'll put that in the first sentence.

16 **Jordan:** And I'll reply to confirm the staffing wording. That isn't me signing off on the launch, though.

17 **Aiko:** Exactly. I'll keep your [8] _____ of receipt separate from my launch decision.

18 **Jordan:** Then we're clear. Six trained today; two more pending; Monday not yet approved.

19 **Aiko:** That's the [9] _____ I needed. Anything else I have interpreted too strongly?

20 **Jordan:** No. Once you've reviewed the Friday check, you can [10] _____ or move the date. I'll wait for that message.

### CHECK THE GAPS

**1.** reservation / **2.** provisional / **3.** in principle / **4.** authorization / **5.** prerequisite / **6.** go/no-go decision / **7.** supersede / **8.** acknowledgment / **9.** read-back / **10.** give the green light

Why these answers fit, page 90

# F Repair the message

## A supplier says "looks good"

### New case / facts you can use

Twelve test units are proposed for Tuesday. The supplier has acknowledged the design, but has not confirmed capacity. Maya owns the purchase decision. Ellis will check supplier capacity by Monday noon.

Choose the correction that preserves the supplied facts. Say the complete corrected message aloud.

**1. Repair the message "Twelve units approved for Tuesday."**

**A.** Twelve units booked; Maya will confirm receipt of the design.
**B.** Twelve units proposed; capacity and Maya's approval are pending.
**C.** Twelve units expected; supplier acknowledgment authorizes the order.
**D.** Twelve units approved; Ellis will check capacity on Monday.

**2. Ellis reports capacity is available. What can Maya now say?**

**A.** Capacity is confirmed; I will make the purchase decision.
**B.** Capacity is confirmed; your check authorizes the purchase.
**C.** Capacity is confirmed; the design acknowledgment becomes approval.
**D.** Capacity is confirmed; Tuesday is now the agreed delivery.

Answers and explanations, page 91

### Listen for the distinction

Stress DESIGN and DATE in the first question. Pause after "No" in Maya's reply, then state the next step without raising your volume.

### Acknowledgment is not authorization

A nod, "fine," or "I see" can acknowledge a message without approving the proposed action. This ambiguity is not unique to any nationality. A manager who hears agreement can check it without embarrassing the speaker: identify the precise decision, name any condition, and read back the record. Do not ask whether the colleague is "really committed" when the unresolved issue is staffing.

# F Say it / then change one fact

## A supplier says "looks good"

Twelve test units are proposed for Tuesday. The supplier has acknowledged the design, but has not confirmed capacity. Maya owns the purchase decision. Ellis will check supplier capacity by Monday noon.

Complete the four gaps. With a partner, read alternate roles, then switch. Studying alone, read both roles and pause before each response.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

approval / proposed / capacity / pending

01 **Maya:** The supplier wrote "looks good." Does that cover the design or the delivery date?

02 **Ellis:** The design. Tuesday remains [1] _____.

03 **Maya:** Then please check [2] _____ by Monday noon.

04 **Ellis:** I will. Shall I place the order if they can supply twelve?

05 **Maya:** No. Bring the confirmation to me for [3] _____.

06 **Ellis:** Understood. I'll send an update by noon, even if the supplier's answer is still [4] _____.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** proposed / **2.** capacity / **3.** approval / **4.** pending

Why these answers fit, page 92

### Second take

Choose the updated response, then say it without looking at the options. Retain every fact in the correct response.

**1. New fact: the supplier confirms capacity, but Maya has not approved the order. Choose Ellis's update.**

**A.** Capacity is confirmed; Maya no longer needs to decide.

**B.** Capacity is confirmed; purchase approval is still pending.

**C.** Capacity is confirmed; Tuesday delivery is now guaranteed.

**D.** Capacity is confirmed; the twelve units are now ordered.

Answers and explanations, page 92

LESSON 02 / CHALLENGE IDEAS RESPECTFULLY

# A Read the situation

Probe evidence, make a concession without surrendering the decision, and set a conduct boundary.

**Pilot proposal / workload assumptions**

| MEASURE | PROPOSAL / AVAILABLE EVIDENCE |
|---|---|
| **Duration** | 6 weeks |
| **Staffing** | 2 account managers; no extra allocation |
| **Follow-up assumption** | 2 hours per account per week |
| **Previous trial** | 4 hours per account per week |
| **Open choice** | Account count can change |

People: Mei, Branch manager; Chris, Commercial lead; Tessa, Operations analyst.

## Read the record

Choose one answer per question using the facts above.

**1. What can Mei change without requesting additional staffing?**

**A.** The meaning of confirmed workload.
**B.** The hours recorded in the earlier trial.
**C.** The number of assigned managers.
**D.** The number of pilot accounts.

**2. Which comparison needs investigation before accepting the estimate?**

**A.** Whether a six-week duration implies half the effort.
**B.** Whether two managers can guarantee the outcome.
**C.** Whether criticism means Chris opposes every pilot.
**D.** Whether the two trials involve comparable follow-up.

**3. Which statement is a personal judgment rather than a task objection?**

**A.** The earlier trial does not support this assumption.
**B.** The planning team does not understand our customers.
**C.** The follow-up estimate omits customer questions.
**D.** The pilot count exceeds the current staffing limit.

Answers and explanations, page 93

# B Vocabulary in use

**CORE TERMS**

### pushback
Resistance or a challenge to a request or proposal.

*offer constructive pushback*

### premise
A starting claim on which an argument depends.

*challenge the premise*

### stress-test
Examine a plan under difficult but plausible conditions.

*stress-test an assumption*

### counterproposal
A different proposal offered in response.

*put forward a counterproposal*

### evidence base
The information supporting a conclusion or estimate.

*strengthen the evidence base*

### concession
A point accepted without necessarily accepting the entire argument.

*make a limited concession*

### feasibility
Whether something can realistically be done.

*assess feasibility*

### capacity constraint
A limit on the work available people or systems can handle.

*work within a capacity constraint*

### non-negotiable
A requirement that cannot be traded away in this discussion.

*state a non-negotiable*

### personal remark
A comment about a person rather than the issue under review.

*avoid personal remarks*

### burden of proof
Responsibility for supplying evidence for a claim.

*meet the burden of proof*

### devil's advocate
Someone testing a position by arguing against it, sometimes without holding that view.

*play devil's advocate*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**premise** PREM-ise

The estimate rests on a two-hour premise.

A premise is an assumption, not a conclusion.

**concession** con-CES-sion

That concession does not settle the whole proposal.

Concede a point; do not concede to a point.

# B Precision and professional shorthand

**EXTEND YOUR RANGE**

### rebuttal
A response that challenges an argument with reasons or evidence.

*offer an evidence-based rebuttal*

### substantiation
Evidence or reasoning that supports a claim.

*request substantiation*

### directional evidence
Information suggesting a tendency without establishing a precise result.

*treat the result as directional evidence*

### point of contention
The particular issue on which people disagree.

*isolate the point of contention*

### ad hominem
Directed at the person instead of addressing the argument.

*avoid ad hominem attacks*

### viable alternative
Another course of action that can realistically work.

*offer a viable alternative*

### rationale
The reasoning behind a choice or proposal.

*explain the rationale*

### extrapolate
Extend a finding beyond the conditions or data directly observed.

*extrapolate from a small trial*

### false dichotomy
Presenting two alternatives as the only choices when others exist.

*challenge a false dichotomy*

### constructive dissent
Reasoned disagreement intended to improve a decision.

*invite constructive dissent*

### red line
An informal term for a limit that must not be crossed.

*state a clear red line*

### common ground
A purpose or position shared by people who disagree.

*establish common ground*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**feasibility** fea-si-BIL-i-ty

We need to check feasibility with two managers.

Feasible means possible within constraints, not desirable.

**extrapolate** ex-TRAP-o-late

Do not extrapolate a full rollout from this small pilot.

A sample may inform a decision without proving the outcome.

# C Phrases that move the work forward

**Ask for the premise**
Which assumption are you challenging?

**Concede one point**
I accept the capacity concern; I do not accept that the whole pilot is unworkable.

**Set a boundary**
Challenge the proposal, please, not the competence of the people presenting it.

**Limit certainty**
That evidence supports a smaller pilot, not a guaranteed failure.

**Narrow the disagreement**
Our point of contention is the time estimate, not the need for the pilot.

**Test a broad claim**
What would have to be true for that conclusion to hold?

**Reject a false choice**
Our choices are not limited to the current plan or canceling the pilot.

**Limit extrapolation**
We should not extrapolate to a full rollout from this sample alone.

**Request evidence**
What are you basing that estimate on?

**Name the distinction**
Let us separate the objective from the proposed method.

**Invite an alternative**
What would a workable version look like within the same staffing limit?

**Close firmly**
We will revise the account count and test the workload before expanding.

**Check comparability**
Which conditions in the earlier trial match the conditions we are proposing?

**Name a shared aim**
We both want a pilot that produces useful evidence without overloading the team.

**Invite a rebuttal**
Which part of that calculation would you dispute?

**Resume after a boundary**
Now that we have addressed the remark, let us compare the two options.

## Same purpose, different register

**Spoken challenge:** I don't buy the two-hour estimate.
**Meeting record:** The two-hour estimate was challenged on workload grounds.

**Firm boundary:** The estimate is fair game. Personal remarks are not.
**Return to the work:** What count would you recommend with the same two managers?

# D Choose the response that fits

Choose one response for each situation. Preserve the facts, the decision boundary, and the purpose of the exchange.

**1. Choose a concession that does not abandon the whole pilot.**

**A.** The four-hour result matters; we should add managers this week.
**B.** The four-hour result matters; the full pilot is therefore impossible.
**C.** The four-hour result matters; we can retain two hours for planning.
**D.** The four-hour result matters; a smaller count may still work.

**2. Chris questions the team's competence. Which response protects both people and scrutiny?**

**A.** Keep the criticism for later; let us approve the current estimate.
**B.** Keep the criticism on the estimate; show us the missing work.
**C.** Keep the criticism private; the team needs a united position today.
**D.** Keep the criticism brief; your remark shows the concern is personal.

**3. Which conclusion is appropriately limited?**

**A.** A smaller pilot can test workload before any wider rollout.
**B.** A smaller pilot confirms the two-hour estimate is realistic.
**C.** A smaller pilot will validate the full rollout once it begins.
**D.** A smaller pilot removes the need to monitor weekly effort.

**4. Which question invites an alternative within the stated limit?**

**A.** What wording would secure approval of the existing pilot plan?
**B.** What estimate would let us retain the current account count?
**C.** What headcount would preserve all the proposed pilot accounts?
**D.** What account count can the same two managers support?

Answers and explanations, page 93

> **One useful distinction**
>
> A concession accepts a particular point, not necessarily the whole argument. A counterproposal offers a different course of action. Constructive pushback needs neither personal agreement nor personal criticism.

# E Conversation

## A sharp objection at the budget review

A branch management meeting about a customer-service pilot.

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once; some entries contain several words.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

non-negotiable / premise / concede / directional evidence / feasible / personal remark / common ground / pushback / baseline / counterproposal

01 **Chris:** I don't buy this estimate. Two managers cannot handle that many accounts and keep their normal work moving.

02 **Mei:** Which [1] _____ is wrong: two hours per account, or how many hours the managers have available?

03 **Chris:** Two hours. The last trial took four. Most of it was customer follow-up, and your new template won't remove that.

04 **Tessa:** I've got the log here. There were fewer handoffs, too, so four hours isn't an obviously inflated [2] _____.

05 **Mei:** All right, I [3] _____ the template won't halve the workload. Can we make a smaller pilot useful?

06 **Chris:** We could, but the team that wrote this clearly doesn't understand the customers.

07 **Mei:** The estimate is fair game. That [4] _____ isn't. Which customer tasks are missing from the sheet?

08 **Chris:** Fair correction. Follow-up calls and escalations. I should have said that rather than judging the team.

09 **Tessa:** Those are in the trial log. If we start with half the accounts, the same two managers could cover the recorded hours.

10 **Mei:** That sounds [5] _____. What would we lose by halving the count?

Conversation continues on the next page.

# A sharp objection at the budget review

**CONVERSATION / CONTINUED**

11 **Chris:** Coverage. We might miss a customer type that creates more work. I wouldn't use a small sample to promise the same result everywhere.

12 **Mei:** Neither would I. We can get [6] _____ without claiming it proves the full rollout will work.

13 **Tessa:** Could we include more than one customer type, then check the actual hours after week one?

14 **Mei:** Yes. Keep the two-manager limit [7] _____ and revise the mix and count around it.

15 **Chris:** I can work with that. I'd also like a stop point if the pilot starts taking time from existing accounts.

16 **Tessa:** I'll propose a workload threshold with operations. We haven't agreed the number yet, so I'll mark it open.

17 **Mei:** Good. We have [8] _____ on protecting existing work. We still need the count and threshold.

18 **Chris:** And I'll correct my comment when I circulate the revision. The sheet missed tasks; I had no basis to question the team's knowledge.

19 **Mei:** Thanks. Your [9] _____ improved the plan. The personal part needed correcting.

20 **Tessa:** I'll update the assumptions and bring the [10] _____ to tomorrow's review. No expansion until we've checked the first results.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** premise / **2.** baseline / **3.** concede / **4.** personal remark / **5.** feasible / **6.** directional evidence / **7.** non-negotiable / **8.** common ground / **9.** pushback / **10.** counterproposal

Why these answers fit, page 94

# F Repair the message

## A forecast with three unconfirmed renewals

### New case / facts you can use

A forecast lists ten confirmed renewals, but only seven customers have confirmed. Three are still deciding. Priya can correct the forecast; she cannot promise the remaining renewals.

Choose the correction that preserves the supplied facts. Say the complete corrected message aloud.

**1. Repair "Ten customers have committed to renew."**

**A.** Seven have confirmed; three decisions remain open.
**B.** Ten are provisional; all seven confirmations need repeating.
**C.** Seven have confirmed; remove the other three permanently.
**D.** Ten are expected; the remaining three are therefore confirmed.

**2. Which challenge requests evidence without questioning competence?**

**A.** Why did your team publish such an unrealistic number?
**B.** Would softer wording keep the ten-renewal total approved?
**C.** What confirmations support the other three entries?
**D.** Can your team guarantee all three remaining renewals?

Answers and explanations, page 95

### Listen for the distinction

Pause after "No" and contrast PENDING with CONFIRMED. Keep the distinction firm without making "you" the stressed word.

### Test the claim; address the delivery

Some colleagues use debate to test a proposal rather than signal personal dislike. That possibility does not excuse contempt. Ask which assumption is challenged and what evidence would change the conclusion. A claim about the plan is different from a judgment about your competence. If the speaker insults people or repeatedly talks over them, name the behavior and set a limit; you do not need to prove hostile intent before doing so.

# F Say it / then change one fact

## A forecast with three unconfirmed renewals

A forecast lists ten confirmed renewals, but only seven customers have confirmed. Three are still deciding. Priya can correct the forecast; she cannot promise the remaining renewals.

Complete the four gaps. With a partner, read alternate roles, then switch. Studying alone, read both roles and pause before each response.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

status / label / evidence / pending

01 **Priya:** I accept the seven confirmations. The other three need a different [1] _____.

02 **Noah:** So you want to remove those customers from the forecast?

03 **Priya:** No. Keep them as [2] _____, not confirmed.

04 **Noah:** That's a narrower correction than I expected. I'll change the [3] _____.

05 **Priya:** Thanks. Please keep the customer confirmations attached as [4] _____.

06 **Noah:** Will do. The total under discussion stays ten; the confirmed count is seven.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** status / **2.** pending / **3.** label / **4.** evidence

Why these answers fit, page 96

### Second take

Choose the updated response, then say it without looking at the options. Retain every fact in the correct response.

**1. New fact: one of the three pending customers confirms. Choose the revised forecast line.**

**A.** Seven renewals are confirmed; the new reply changes nothing.

**B.** Eight renewals are forecast; the other two are lost.

**C.** Ten renewals are confirmed; two confirmations will arrive later.

**D.** Eight renewals are confirmed; two remain pending.

Answers and explanations, page 96

# Review 1 / A launch memo under pressure

Use language from the lessons you have completed. Choose one answer per question.

> **Case file**
>
> Lena's memo says "Thursday approved." The sponsor actually said "The approach is sensible." Four reviewers are confirmed; six are required. Two bookings are pending. A colleague says the capacity assumption is weak. Lena owns the launch decision.

**1. Which label belongs on Thursday?**

**A.** Canceled; two reviewers have not yet confirmed.
**B.** Approved; the sponsor liked the general approach.
**C.** Proposed; reviewer readiness and authorization are still open.
**D.** Confirmed; the bookings complete the reviewer requirement.

**2. Which question tests the criticism instead of guessing a motive?**

**A.** Can you support the team by withholding the concern?
**B.** Why are you resisting the sponsor's chosen direction?
**C.** Would a more positive tone remove the capacity problem?
**D.** Which workload assumption needs different evidence?

**3. Choose the accurate distinction.**

**A.** Acknowledgment and authorization both mean final approval.
**B.** Acknowledgment permits action; authorization records receipt.
**C.** Acknowledgment records understanding; authorization permits action.
**D.** Acknowledgment is opposition; authorization is tentative support.

**4. Which response accepts scrutiny and sets a boundary?**

**A.** Test the team's loyalty before reviewing the capacity estimate.
**B.** Leave both the estimate and the team out of the discussion.
**C.** Test the capacity estimate; leave judgments about the team out.
**D.** Accept the estimate first; challenge its authors privately later.

Answers and explanations, page 121

LESSON 03 / MAKE AUTHORITY AND PARTICIPATION CLEAR

# A Read the situation

Define decision rights, invite recommendations, and delegate within explicit limits.

**Two-week onboarding trial / authority card**

| DECISION | AUTHORITY IN THIS TRIAL |
|---|---|
| **Internal task order** | Alex may decide |
| **Customer promises** | Sofia must approve |
| **Additional spending** | Sofia must approve |
| **Continuation** | Review after 2 weeks; no automatic extension |

People: Sofia, International customer-service manager; Alex, US-based team lead.

## Read the record

Choose one answer per question using the facts above.

**1. Which action is already within Alex's authority?**

**A.** Buy a small tool to speed the trial up.
**B.** Move an internal check earlier in the task order.
**C.** Promise a customer an earlier completion date.
**D.** Extend the trial if the team prefers it.

**2. The team recommends a paid tool. What happens next?**

**A.** The team votes and Alex treats that as approval.
**B.** Alex brings the proposal to Sofia for approval.
**C.** Sofia delegates all trial decisions to the vendor.
**D.** Alex buys it and informs Sofia afterward.

**3. What does the two-week checkpoint establish?**

**A.** An extension unless Sofia actively objects.
**B.** An automatic return to the original sequence.
**C.** A point to review continuation, not an extension.
**D.** An end to Sofia's oversight of the trial.

Answers and explanations, page 97

# B Vocabulary in use

**CORE TERMS**

### decision rights
Who may recommend, approve, or decide a particular matter.

*clarify decision rights*

### discretion
Freedom to choose within stated limits.

*exercise discretion*

### escalation threshold
The point at which an issue must go to another authority.

*agree an escalation threshold*

### consultation
Seeking input before an action or decision.

*hold a consultation*

### accountability
Responsibility for explaining actions and following through.

*retain accountability*

### exception
A case that falls outside the normal rule or arrangement.

*approve an exception*

### delegation
Giving another person defined responsibility or authority.

*delegate a decision*

### guardrail
A limit intended to keep a decision within an acceptable range.

*set clear guardrails*

### decision owner
The person accountable for making a particular decision.

*name the decision owner*

### consensus
Broad agreement, which must not be inferred from silence alone.

*build consensus*

### remit
The area of work or authority assigned to a role.

*stay within your remit*

### RACI
A role map: Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, Informed. Organizations may apply it differently.

*use a RACI matrix*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**discretion** dis-CRE-tion

Use your discretion on task order, within these limits.

Discretion is bounded choice, not unlimited authority.

**accountability** ac-count-a-BIL-i-ty

Delegation does not remove my accountability for the trial.

Doing a task and answering for its result are different roles.

# B Precision and professional shorthand

**EXTEND YOUR RANGE**

### mandate

An assigned purpose and authority to carry out work.

*define the team's mandate*

### autonomy

Freedom to organize or decide work within agreed limits.

*grant operational autonomy*

### approval boundary

The point beyond which a decision needs another person's permission.

*respect the approval boundary*

### retained authority

Decision power that is not passed to the person doing the work.

*specify retained authority*

### decision gate

A checkpoint at which a named owner decides whether work may proceed.

*pass a decision gate*

### span of control

The number of people or teams directly supervised by one manager.

*review a manager's span of control*

### separation of duties

Dividing important tasks among roles to reduce conflicts or unchecked control.

*maintain separation of duties*

### oversight

Monitoring and review by someone responsible for the work.

*retain management oversight*

### accountable owner

The person answerable for a specified result or decision.

*name an accountable owner*

### approval matrix

A table showing who can approve which decisions and limits.

*check the approval matrix*

### revocable

Able to be withdrawn by the person or body granting it.

*grant revocable authority*

### informed stakeholder

Someone who needs updates but does not necessarily decide.

*keep an informed stakeholder updated*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**remit** RE-mit

Buying software is outside this trial's remit.

Remit means assigned scope; permission concerns a particular action.

**consultation** con-sul-TA-tion

Consultation gives us input; Sofia makes the spending decision.

Consultation is not a vote or automatic consent.

# C Phrases that move the work forward

**Invite a recommendation**

Bring me your preferred option and the reason for it.

**Reserve a decision**

Customer commitments remain my decision.

**Define an escalation**

If the change affects a customer promise, bring it back to me.

**Prevent silent consent**

I will ask each owner to confirm the responsibilities assigned to them.

**Define autonomy**

Within the agreed limits, the task order is yours to decide.

**Check a boundary**

Does this change fall within the authority you have delegated to me?

**Name the accountable owner**

Let us name one person who is answerable for the trial result.

**Explain the checkpoint**

The two-week review is a decision gate, not automatic permission to continue.

**Delegate clearly**

You may change the internal sequence without seeking approval each time.

**Set a limit**

That discretion does not include additional spending.

**Distinguish roles**

I need your input; I am not asking you to make the final decision.

**Schedule review**

We will review the trial after two weeks using the agreed criteria.

**Keep oversight explicit**

I am delegating the sequence, not stepping away from oversight.

**Distinguish recommendation and action**

You may recommend the tool, but purchasing it still requires approval.

**Require timely escalation**

Raise the issue before making the customer commitment, not afterward.

**Confirm understanding**

Please state which decisions you can make and which you will bring back to me.

## Same purpose, different register

**Everyday instruction:** You can reorder the internal tasks.
**Authority record:** Alex has delegated authority over internal task sequencing.

**Recommendation:** I recommend buying the scheduling tool.
**Authorization:** I approve the additional purchase. These are not interchangeable.

# D Choose the response that fits

Choose one response for each situation. Preserve the facts, the decision boundary, and the purpose of the exchange.

**1. Which instruction delegates clearly without disappearing?**

**A.** Take full ownership; keep every customer date exactly as proposed.
**B.** Choose the internal sequence; bring spending and promises back to me.
**C.** Consult the team; treat their agreement as permission to proceed.
**D.** Use your judgment; tell me later about any changes you make.

**2. Alex hears "You own this." Which clarification is most useful?**

**A.** Does that mean customer dates no longer need documenting?
**B.** Does that mean I can stop sending you trial information?
**C.** Does that include purchases, or just the internal sequence?
**D.** Does that mean you trust the team to handle every issue?

**3. Which escalation happens at the right time?**

**A.** The change affects a customer promise; I need approval before offering it.
**B.** The change affects a customer promise; I will mention it at the final review.
**C.** The change affects a customer promise; I will let the team approve it.
**D.** The change affects a customer promise; I will seek approval after acceptance.

**4. Choose a record that distinguishes consultation from decision.**

**A.** Alex gathered team input; the vendor now owns the decision.
**B.** Alex gathered team input; that input authorizes the purchase.
**C.** Alex gathered team input; Sofia's silence will count as consent.
**D.** Alex gathered team input; Sofia will decide on the purchase.

Answers and explanations, page 97

> **One useful distinction**
>
> Consultation asks for input; consensus requires shared agreement. Delegation grants specified authority, not unlimited discretion. State the remit and escalation threshold before asking someone to take ownership.

# E Conversation

## Delegating without disappearing

A planning conversation about a new customer-onboarding process.

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once; some entries contain several words.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

decision rights / decision owner / accountability / use discretion / within your remit / decision gate / requires approval / without approval / keep oversight / approval boundary

01 **Alex:** Can we stop sending every tiny sequence change to you? Yesterday we waited half a day to move one internal check.

02 **Sofia:** Yes. I've made myself a bottleneck. Let's make the [1] _____ explicit for this two-week trial.

03 **Alex:** I'd like the team to choose the order. They see the queues before either of us does.

04 **Sofia:** That's [2] _____. You can change the sequence without asking me each time.

05 **Alex:** Including moving a customer delivery forward if it helps the queue?

06 **Sofia:** No, that's the [3] _____. Internal order is yours; customer promises still come to me.

07 **Alex:** Got it. Suppose the new order needs a paid scheduling tool?

08 **Sofia:** Recommend it, with the cost. You can [4] _____ on the internal sequence; buying the tool still needs my approval.

09 **Alex:** So I can make a recommendation, but not place an order. I'd rather know that now than find out after a purchase.

10 **Sofia:** Exactly. Those are the two guardrails: no extra spending and no changed customer promises [5] _____.

Conversation continues on the next page.

# Delegating without disappearing

**CONVERSATION / CONTINUED**

11 **Alex:** Can I ask the team for a quick vote on the sequence?

12 **Sofia:** You can consult them. You remain the [6] _____ for that sequence; you don't need unanimous agreement.

13 **Alex:** That helps. I'll explain what we chose and record the concern if someone sees a risk.

14 **Sofia:** Please do. And use the existing tracker so I can [7] _____ without becoming another approval step.

15 **Alex:** How often do you want an update? I don't want to replace ten approval requests with ten progress emails.

16 **Sofia:** One summary at the end of each week. Escalate earlier if the change [8] _____ under either limit we just named.

17 **Alex:** Before I make the promise or spend the money, not after. And the trial ends after two weeks?

18 **Sofia:** We review it then. That [9] _____ is not automatic permission to continue.

19 **Alex:** I'll put that on the authority card. The sequence is mine; spending and promises come back to you; we review continuation together.

20 **Sofia:** Good. I'm delegating choices, not dropping [10] _____. Bring me a recommendation if the boundaries stop the trial from being useful.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** decision rights / **2.** within your remit / **3.** approval boundary / **4.** use discretion / **5.** without approval / **6.** decision owner / **7.** keep oversight / **8.** requires approval / **9.** decision gate / **10.** accountability

Why these answers fit, page 98

# F Repair the message

## A venue change inside a fixed budget

> **New case / facts you can use**
>
> Nora may move an internal workshop between existing rooms. Any external booking requires Luis's approval, even if its price is low. Nora must recommend an option before Monday's review.

Choose the correction that preserves the supplied facts. Say the complete corrected message aloud.

**1. Repair "Any inexpensive room change is approved."**

**A.** Low-cost external bookings are delegated; larger ones need Luis's approval.
**B.** All room changes are delegated; Luis only reviews the final schedule.
**C.** Existing-room changes are delegated; external bookings need Luis's approval.
**D.** Existing-room changes need approval; external options can be booked provisionally.

**2. The team favors an external room. What can Nora report?**

**A.** The price is low; the external room is already within my remit.
**B.** The review is Monday; the room is approved until then.
**C.** The team recommends it; the booking is not yet authorized.
**D.** The team supports it; the vote authorizes the booking.

Answers and explanations, page 99

> **Listen for the distinction**
>
> Contrast RECOMMEND with BOOK. Pause before "before reserving anything outside" so the timing of approval is clear.

> **Consultation is not a vote**
>
> A manager can invite disagreement and still own the final decision. Conversely, an invitation to "take ownership" does not tell a team which decisions it can make. The missing information is authority, not confidence. Specify what is delegated, what needs consultation, and what remains reserved. Do not equate an employee's request for clarity with reluctance to lead, or a confident suggestion with a claim to unlimited authority.

# F Say it / then change one fact

## A venue change inside a fixed budget

Nora may move an internal workshop between existing rooms. Any external booking requires Luis's approval, even if its price is low. Nora must recommend an option before Monday's review.

Complete the four gaps. With a partner, read alternate roles, then switch. Studying alone, read both roles and pause before each response.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

decision / recommendation / booking / authority

01 **Nora:** The team recommends the external room, but I have not made a [1] _____.

02 **Luis:** Good. Is there an internal alternative?

03 **Nora:** Yes. Moving to room B is within my [2] _____.

04 **Luis:** Bring both options to Monday's review. I want your [3] _____.

05 **Nora:** I'll include the costs and wait for your [4] _____ before reserving anything outside.

06 **Luis:** That works. You can still move the internal session if you need to.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** booking / **2.** authority / **3.** recommendation / **4.** decision

Why these answers fit, page 100

### Second take

Choose the updated response, then say it without looking at the options. Retain every fact in the correct response.

**1. New fact: Luis approves the external room for this workshop only. Choose Nora's read-back.**

**A.** I may only recommend the room; no booking has been approved.

**B.** I may book any external room while the price remains low.

**C.** I may book this room for every workshop in the coming year.

**D.** I may book this room for this workshop, not future sessions.

Answers and explanations, page 100

LESSON 04 / NEGOTIATE REALISTIC COMMITMENTS

# A Read the situation

Offer bounded alternatives, use conditional commitments, and distinguish a forecast from a promise.

**Reporting options / all times New York local time**

| VERSION | EARLIEST SUPPORTED DELIVERY | STATUS |
|---|---|---|
| **Planning estimate** | Friday, 3 p.m. | Provisional; reconciliation incomplete |
| **Verified figures** | Monday, noon | After Monday-morning reconciliation |
| **Choice owner** | Priya | Can choose version, not accelerate supplier work |

People: Omar, International branch operations manager; Priya, Headquarters project sponsor.

## Read the record

Choose one answer per question using the facts above.

**1. What is available by Friday at 3 p.m. New York time?**

**A.** Verified figures with supplier approval.
**B.** A final report awaiting a cosmetic update.
**C.** A confirmed result with an optional caveat.
**D.** An estimate labeled provisional.

**2. Which constraint can Priya change in this case?**

**A.** The meaning of a verified figure.
**B.** The requirement to label an estimate.
**C.** The supplier reconciliation completion time.
**D.** The version selected for Friday's meeting.

**3. Which detail prevents a cross-office deadline misunderstanding?**

**A.** Friday, before the sponsor finishes work.
**B.** Friday, 3 p.m., New York local time.
**C.** Friday, at the branch's usual reporting time.
**D.** Friday afternoon, before close of business.

Answers and explanations, page 101

# B Vocabulary in use

**CORE TERMS**

### deliverable
A specific output someone agrees to provide.

*define the deliverable*

### trade-off
A choice in which one benefit comes at the cost of another.

*make a trade-off*

### verified
Checked against the required evidence or process.

*verified figures*

### caveat
A stated limitation or qualification.

*include a caveat*

### contingency
A provision or alternative for a possible problem.

*plan a contingency*

### best effort
An undertaking to try, not necessarily to deliver a result.

*make a best-effort attempt*

### turnaround time
Time from a request or input to a completed response.

*agree a turnaround time*

### reconciliation
Checking records against one another and resolving differences.

*complete the reconciliation*

### estimate
An approximate figure based on available information.

*provide an estimate*

### scope creep
Uncontrolled growth of the work beyond the agreed scope.

*prevent scope creep*

### hard deadline
A deadline treated as fixed for the stated purpose.

*meet a hard deadline*

### overcommit
Promise more than the available capacity can support.

*avoid overcommitting*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**reconciliation** rec-on-cil-i-A-tion

Verification depends on supplier reconciliation.

Reconciliation checks records against one another; it is not presentation formatting.

**provisional estimate** pro-VI-sion-al ES-ti-mate

The Friday version is a provisional estimate.

An estimate can be useful without being verified.

# B Precision and professional shorthand

**EXTEND YOUR RANGE**

### critical path

The sequence of dependent work that determines the earliest completion date.

*identify the critical path*

### buffer

Extra time or capacity kept available for variation or delay.

*build in a time buffer*

### slippage

Movement of a task or delivery beyond its planned date.

*report schedule slippage*

### baseline

An agreed starting plan used to compare later performance or changes.

*establish a schedule baseline*

### rebaseline

Formally replace an agreed plan with a revised reference plan.

*rebaseline the delivery schedule*

### dependency risk

The possibility that required work elsewhere will delay or block delivery.

*flag a dependency risk*

### minimum viable scope

The smallest set of work that can still meet the stated purpose.

*agree the minimum viable scope*

### rolling forecast

A forecast updated regularly as new information becomes available.

*maintain a rolling forecast*

### range estimate

An estimate expressed as a lower and upper value rather than a single figure.

*provide a range estimate*

### confidence level

Here, the stated strength of confidence in an estimate, with its basis explained.

*state the confidence level*

### resource allocation

The assignment of people, time, or other capacity to work.

*confirm resource allocation*

### acceptance criteria

The conditions an output must meet to be accepted as complete.

*agree acceptance criteria*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**caveat** CA-ve-at

Keep the caveat attached when you forward the slide.

A caveat qualifies a claim; it is not a separate correction later.

**acceptance criteria** ac-CEP-tance cri-TE-ri-a

The acceptance criteria specify a labeled estimate.

Criteria is plural; criterion is singular.

# C Phrases that move the work forward

**Identify the purpose**

What decision does the Friday meeting need to make?

**Make a conditional offer**

We can meet Friday if the deliverable is an explicitly provisional estimate.

**Protect the caveat**

Please keep the provisional label when the figures are forwarded.

**Separate effort from outcome**

I can commit to the update; I cannot guarantee a result we do not control.

**Ask what is essential**

Which parts of the report are essential for Friday's decision?

**Protect capacity**

To include the other branches, we would need to move the date or reassign people.

**Agree what complete means**

For this version, does "complete" mean ready for discussion or verified for release?

**Preserve the original plan**

Let us record the revised deadline alongside the original baseline.

**Offer alternatives**

We can provide an estimate on Friday or verified figures on Monday.

**State a firm limit**

I cannot commit to verified figures before the reconciliation is complete.

**Check the deadline**

Does "Friday" mean 3 p.m. New York time or your local end of day?

**Confirm the choice**

Then our agreement is Friday estimates, followed by Monday verification.

**Identify the dependency**

The supplier check is on the critical path; extra formatting time will not shorten it.

**Make uncertainty visible**

I can give a range and explain its basis, but a single figure would imply false precision.

**Report slippage early**

The check is at risk of slipping; I will update you before the agreed deadline.

**Confirm a fallback**

If verification is delayed, the fallback is a status update, not an unchecked final report.

## Same purpose, different register

**Firm spoken limit:** I can send an estimate Friday, not verified figures.
**Written delivery line:** Friday, 3 p.m. New York time: provisional planning estimate.

**Clarify the purpose:** What does the meeting need to decide?
**Protect a qualification:** Please retain "provisional" wherever these figures are reused.

# D Choose the response that fits

Choose one response for each situation. Preserve the facts, the decision boundary, and the purpose of the exchange.

**1. Choose a firm commitment Omar can support.**

**A.** I can send a final Friday report and verify its figures on Monday.
**B.** I can send verified figures Friday if the meeting needs them urgently.
**C.** I can send confirmed numbers Friday with a note about Monday's check.
**D.** I can send a provisional estimate Friday at 3 p.m. New York time.

**2. Priya says "Just do your best." What should Omar clarify?**

**A.** I can commit to the estimate; verification still needs Monday's check.
**B.** I will aim for verified figures; let us leave the exact version open.
**C.** I will treat your request as approval to skip the supplier check.
**D.** I will label the report final so that the meeting can proceed.

**3. Which wording preserves the caveat when figures are forwarded?**

**A.** Replace "provisional" with "confirmed" if nobody raises a concern.
**B.** Retain "provisional" until the presentation begins on Friday.
**C.** Remove "provisional" from the slide but keep it in our private notes.
**D.** Retain "provisional" on the slide and in the covering message.

**4. Supplier reconciliation slips. What is the responsible fallback?**

**A.** Send a status update and a revised verification time.
**B.** Wait for final figures and let the agreed update deadline pass.
**C.** Keep Monday's label and send the figures without mentioning the delay.
**D.** Release the estimate as verified to preserve the original deadline.

Answers and explanations, page 101

> **One useful distinction**
>
> A deliverable is the output promised; a deadline is when it is due. A caveat states a limitation; a contingency states the fallback. An estimate can be useful without being verified, provided its status stays visible.

# E Conversation

## Friday estimates or Monday verified figures

A call between a US branch and a headquarters sponsor.

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once; some entries contain several words.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

caveat / contingency / dependency / trade-off / acceptance criteria / scope / provisional / prioritize / deadline / Verified

01 **Priya:** I need the branch figures for Friday's planning meeting. Can you get me the final version by three?

02 **Omar:** An estimate, yes. [1] _____ figures, no. The supplier reconciliation won't finish until Monday morning.

03 **Priya:** We've had this meeting booked for weeks. What can I actually show the directors?

04 **Omar:** A planning estimate labeled [2] _____. What decision do they need to make on Friday?

05 **Priya:** They need to choose which branches to examine first. They aren't approving the final allocation yet.

06 **Omar:** Then the estimate may serve that purpose. The [3] _____ is speed versus verification, not a choice between sending something and sending nothing.

07 **Priya:** Can we keep the slide simple? A large warning makes it look as if we haven't done the work.

08 **Omar:** We can keep it short, but the [4] _____ has to stay. "Provisional; supplier check pending" would do it.

09 **Priya:** All right. Three on Friday means my afternoon. You're in New York, correct?

10 **Omar:** Yes. Let's make the [5] _____ three p.m. New York time. Does that reach you before the meeting?

Conversation continues on the next page.

# Friday estimates or Monday verified figures

**CONVERSATION / CONTINUED**

11 **Priya:** It does. Could you include the other two branches while you're at it?

12 **Omar:** Not within that [6] _____. I can send this branch on Friday. Adding two more means changing the date or assigning help.

13 **Priya:** Keep this branch. I'll tell the directors what is and isn't in the version.

14 **Omar:** Thanks. The supplier check is the [7] _____ for Monday. More formatting time won't make it finish earlier.

15 **Priya:** Understood. Monday at noon, New York time, for the verified figures?

16 **Omar:** Yes, based on the check finishing that morning. If it slips, I'll send a status update by noon rather than an unchecked final report.

17 **Priya:** That gives me a [8] _____. Please put both delivery lines in the same message.

18 **Omar:** I will. Friday estimate, Monday verification or a status update if the dependency moves. Please keep the label when you forward the numbers.

19 **Priya:** Agreed. I'll use the Friday version only to [9] _____ the reviews, not as approval of the allocation.

20 **Omar:** Then we have clear [10] _____: this branch, labeled estimate, three p.m. New York time. I'll send the confirmation now.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** Verified / **2.** provisional / **3.** trade-off / **4.** caveat / **5.** deadline / **6.** scope / **7.** dependency / **8.** contingency / **9.** prioritize / **10.** acceptance criteria

Why these answers fit, page 102

# F Repair the message

## A translation deadline with two deliverables

> **New case / facts you can use**
>
> A client wants a six-page internal briefing Friday. Nia can send the translated text Friday at 2 p.m. New York time. Independent language review finishes Monday at 11 a.m. New York time. Friday's version must be labeled "review pending."

Choose the correction that preserves the supplied facts. Say the complete corrected message aloud.

### 1. Repair "Reviewed translation available Friday."

**A.** Translation Friday; review becomes optional after client acceptance.
**B.** Translation Friday; independent review completed Monday.
**C.** Translation Monday; the Friday text must not be used internally.
**D.** Reviewed translation Friday; reviewer confirmation follows Monday.

### 2. Which Friday covering line preserves the limitation?

**A.** Final reviewed text attached; minor language checks follow Monday.
**B.** Finished text attached; the reviewer has been informed of delivery.
**C.** Internal briefing text attached; independent review is pending.
**D.** Approved text attached; please ignore any earlier review labels.

Answers and explanations, page 103

> **Listen for the distinction**
>
> Stress TEXT in "text delivery" and FINAL in "final sign-off." Read both times with the location, even when the other person seems to know it.

> **A clear limit can protect trust**
>
> A quick "yes" may reduce tension in the call while creating a commitment the branch cannot meet. A vague "we will try" can also be heard as a promise. Name the deliverable, deadline, and condition separately. Offer a choice that serves the other person's purpose. Do not present willingness as capacity, or describe a required accuracy check as resistance to headquarters.

# F Say it / then change one fact

## A translation deadline with two deliverables

A client wants a six-page internal briefing Friday. Nia can send the translated text Friday at 2 p.m. New York time. Independent language review finishes Monday at 11 a.m. New York time. Friday's version must be labeled "review pending."

Complete the four gaps. With a partner, read alternate roles, then switch. Studying alone, read both roles and pause before each response.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

sign-off / version / checkpoint / review

01 **Nia:** I can send the translated text Friday. The independent [1] _____ finishes Monday.

02 **Client:** Can the directors use Friday's text for their internal briefing?

03 **Nia:** Yes, with "review pending" kept on that [2] _____.

04 **Client:** Then Friday is a text delivery, not a final [3] _____.

05 **Nia:** Exactly. I'll confirm both delivery times in New York local time, including Monday's [4] _____.

06 **Client:** Please do. I'll keep the review label in the briefing pack.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** review / **2.** version / **3.** sign-off / **4.** checkpoint

Why these answers fit, page 104

### Second take

Choose the updated response, then say it without looking at the options. Retain every fact in the correct response.

**1. New fact: the independent reviewer is delayed. Choose Nia's Monday update.**

**A.** Review is still pending; I will send a revised completion time.
**B.** Review is now complete because Monday was the agreed deadline.
**C.** Review is confidential; keep calling Friday's text the final version.
**D.** Review is unnecessary because Friday's text reached the directors.

Answers and explanations, page 104

# Review 2 / A presentation and a purchase

Use language from the lessons you have completed. Choose one answer per question.

> **Case file**
>
> Eva may change an internal presentation sequence. External design purchases require Malik's approval. A paid design can be recommended Friday, but a checked cost estimate will not be available until Monday. The Friday meeting can review a provisional estimate.

**1. Which action can Eva take now?**

**A.** Promise payment Friday and ask Malik to approve it Monday.
**B.** Reorder the internal presentation without buying external design.
**C.** Buy the design if the team agrees with the recommendation.
**D.** Approve the vendor because a checked estimate is due Monday.

**2. Which Friday message is accurate?**

**A.** Design rejected; cost unavailable; Friday's review must be canceled.
**B.** Design recommended; cost estimate provisional; purchase approval pending.
**C.** Design approved; cost estimate checked; payment can proceed Friday.
**D.** Design purchased; cost estimate provisional; approval follows Monday.

**3. The sponsor asks for a "final" Friday estimate. Choose the reply.**

**A.** Friday can be verified as long as the label is removed later.
**B.** Friday can be final if we keep the Monday check private.
**C.** Friday can be provisional; the check finishes Monday.
**D.** Friday can be final because a recommendation implies approval.

**4. Which item belongs in the written commitment?**

**A.** Presentation style, meeting preference, and implied authority.
**B.** Version, delivery time, time zone, and pending dependency.
**C.** Version, a hopeful completion date, and assumed approval.
**D.** General effort, informal reassurance, and no stated limitation.

Answers and explanations, page 122

LESSON 05 / INCLUDE EVERY VOICE IN A MEETING

# A Read the situation

Manage turn-taking, interrupt constructively, paraphrase accurately, and close a hybrid meeting.

**Meeting panel / 15 minutes remaining**

| CHANNEL | INFORMATION AVAILABLE |
|---|---|
| **Room discussion** | Ben has prepared the customer-service schedule |
| **Chat: Arun** | Routing check incomplete; concern not yet discussed |
| **Launch condition** | Routing must be checked before go-live |
| **Decision owner** | Leila |

People: Leila, International manager and meeting chair; Ben, US-based service lead; Arun, Remote systems lead.

## Read the record

Choose one answer per question using the facts above.

**1. Which issue is easy to miss in the current discussion?**

**A.** Leila's completed authorization of go-live.
**B.** The team's agreed removal of routing checks.
**C.** Arun's unaddressed routing concern in chat.
**D.** Ben's unprepared customer-service schedule.

**2. What prevents the team from treating the queue as ready?**

**A.** The meeting has only fifteen minutes left.
**B.** The customer-service schedule is prepared.
**C.** Arun entered the concern through chat.
**D.** The routing check is not complete.

**3. Who should state the go-live decision after the evidence is reviewed?**

**A.** Arun, because he checks the routing.
**B.** Ben, because the service schedule is ready.
**C.** Leila, the named decision owner.
**D.** The last speaker, if nobody objects.

Answers and explanations, page 105

# B Vocabulary in use

**CORE TERMS**

### turn-taking
The way speakers enter, hold, and give up a speaking turn.

*manage turn-taking*

### crosstalk
Overlapping speech that makes contributions hard to follow.

*reduce crosstalk*

### round-robin
A sequence in which each participant is invited to contribute.

*use a round-robin*

### parking lot
An informal list of issues deferred for later attention.

*put an item in the parking lot*

### quorum
The minimum attendance required under a group's rules for valid business.

*confirm a quorum*

### decision log
A record of decisions, owners, and relevant reasons or conditions.

*update the decision log*

### the floor
The opportunity to speak to the group.

*give someone the floor*

### timebox
A fixed amount of time allocated to a discussion or task.

*timebox the discussion*

### paraphrase
Restate someone's meaning in different words.

*paraphrase a concern*

### dissent
A stated view that differs from the proposal or majority view.

*record dissent*

### action item
A specific task recorded for follow-up.

*assign an action item*

### asynchronous input
A contribution made outside a simultaneous meeting.

*collect asynchronous input*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**crosstalk** CROSS-talk

The remote team cannot follow the crosstalk.

Crosstalk is overlapping speech, not substantive disagreement.

**paraphrase** PAR-a-phrase

Let me paraphrase the routing concern.

Paraphrase meaning; do not replace it with your preferred interpretation.

# B Precision and professional shorthand

**EXTEND YOUR RANGE**

### facilitation

Helping a group follow a workable process and make progress.

*provide neutral facilitation*

### airtime

The amount of meeting time a person uses to speak.

*share airtime fairly*

### unresolved question

A question that has not yet received an adequate answer.

*return to an unresolved question*

### cross-check

Compare information with another source or person to check accuracy.

*cross-check the meeting summary*

### side conversation

A separate exchange that can distract from the main discussion.

*pause a side conversation*

### meeting owner

The person responsible for arranging and following through on a meeting.

*confirm the meeting owner*

### speaking queue

The order in which waiting participants will be invited to speak.

*manage the speaking queue*

### agenda item

A specific topic scheduled for discussion.

*close an agenda item*

### synthesis

A summary that connects important points from several contributions.

*offer a concise synthesis*

### recap

A short restatement of the main points just covered.

*give a brief recap*

### deferred item

An issue deliberately moved to a later time.

*assign an owner to a deferred item*

### pre-read

Material circulated for participants to read before a meeting.

*circulate the pre-read*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**dissent** dis-SENT

The record should preserve Arun's dissent.

Dissent is disagreement, not personal disloyalty.

**asynchronous** a-SYN-chro-nous

Send asynchronous input before the next review.

The contributions need not arrive at the same time.

# C Phrases that move the work forward

**Stop overlap**

One voice at a time, please; the remote line cannot distinguish us.

**Enter the discussion**

May I come in on the routing point before we move on?

**Check a paraphrase**

Have I represented your concern accurately?

**Record dissent**

I will record the concern without describing it as agreement.

**Manage the queue**

I have Ben, then Arun, then Leila in the speaking queue.

**Include a missed voice**

We have not heard from the remote team yet; what would you add on routing?

**Check access to information**

Can everyone see the same version of the pre-read?

**Preserve an objection**

The summary will show that the scheduling proposal still has an unresolved objection.

**Protect a turn**

Arun has not finished. I will come to you next, Ben.

**Invite a specific view**

Arun, what remains unverified in the routing check?

**Limit a digression**

Let us park the training format and finish the go-live conditions.

**Close with ownership**

The next action belongs to Arun; the go-live decision remains with me.

**Pause a side exchange**

Please pause the side conversation so everyone can hear the answer.

**Connect two contributions**

Ben has confirmed the staffing; Arun has identified a separate routing condition.

**Keep a deferred item alive**

We will defer the slide layout, with Ben bringing it back on Thursday.

**Close an item accurately**

We have assigned the checks, but we have not approved go-live.

## Same purpose, different register

**Taking a turn:** Can I come in on routing before we move on?
**Chairing a turn:** Arun first, then Ben. We need the routing result before a decision.

**Spoken summary:** Staffing is ready; routing is not checked yet.
**Decision log:** Go-live remains pending. Arun owns the routing check; Leila owns the decision.

# D Choose the response that fits

Choose one response for each situation. Preserve the facts, the decision boundary, and the purpose of the exchange.

**1. Ben interrupts Arun. Choose an intervention that protects both turns.**

**A.** Ben, finish quickly. Arun can add anything important by email.
**B.** Both of you, keep going. I will combine your points afterward.
**C.** Arun, finish the routing point. Ben, you are next.
**D.** Arun, let Ben finish. We already have your concern in chat.

**2. Which paraphrase preserves Arun's concern?**

**A.** Routing is routine; Arun can finish it after customers arrive.
**B.** Routing is unverified; a ready schedule does not settle it.
**C.** Routing is ready; Arun prefers a later launch for convenience.
**D.** Routing is rejected; Arun recommends canceling the entire service.

**3. The discussion drifts to slide design. Which line parks it responsibly?**

**A.** Ben, bring the slide choice Thursday; routing comes first now.
**B.** Ben, settle the slide choice now; routing can wait until launch.
**C.** Ben, leave the slide choice open; we will remember it later.
**D.** Ben, drop the slide choice; it has no value to anyone here.

**4. Which closing record is accurate before the routing result arrives?**

**A.** Go-live authorized; routing information to follow.
**B.** Schedule rejected; customer-service preparation must restart.
**C.** Arun dissents; his silence later will count as approval.
**D.** Checks assigned; go-live not yet authorized.

Answers and explanations, page 105

> **One useful distinction**
>
> Giving someone the floor transfers the speaking turn, not decision authority. An action item assigns work; a decision log records what has been decided or remains pending. Neither silence nor attendance establishes approval.

# E Conversation

## The remote question nobody heard

A hybrid meeting about switching to a new customer-support queue.

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once; some entries contain several words.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

crosstalk / parking lot / unresolved question / paraphrase / timebox / unverified / action item / decision is pending / recap the next steps / decision log

01 **Ben:** The schedule is ready, so can we confirm go-live? I need to tell the supervisors before they leave.

02 **Arun:** I've put a routing issue in chat. The check isn't finished, and one of the queues might still send cases to the old team.

03 **Ben:** We can fix a routing detail after we start. The staffing is the difficult part, and that's done.

04 **Leila:** Pause. We have [1] _____, and Arun hasn't finished. Arun, you have the floor; Ben, you're next.

05 **Arun:** Thanks. I haven't confirmed a fault. I'm saying the routing is [2] _____. We need the result before we send customers into the queue.

06 **Leila:** So the schedule is ready, but readiness depends on a separate routing check. Is that a fair [3] _____?

07 **Arun:** Yes. I'm not asking to redo the schedule. I need time to finish the check.

08 **Ben:** That helps. I heard "the whole launch isn't ready," and thought you wanted us to start planning again.

09 **Leila:** Let's keep the two workstreams separate. We have fifteen minutes, so I'll [4] _____ this item to five minutes to agree the next actions.

10 **Ben:** Can we also settle which slide the supervisors will see? I have two versions and the colors are confusing.

Conversation continues on the next page.

# The remote question nobody heard

**CONVERSATION / CONTINUED**

11 **Leila:** Put the slide choice in the [5] _____. Bring it back Thursday. First, what does Arun need to finish routing?

12 **Arun:** Access to the current mapping file. I only have yesterday's version. Ben, can you send the link you used?

13 **Ben:** Yes, now. I didn't realize we were working from different versions.

14 **Arun:** I've got it. I'll check the mapping and report the result by three p.m. New York time.

15 **Leila:** That's the [6] _____. Ben sends the file; Arun checks and reports; I make the go-live decision.

16 **Ben:** Can I tell the supervisors we're likely to start, provided the result is clear?

17 **Leila:** Tell them the [7] _____. I'd rather not have a conditional message become "approved" as it gets passed on.

18 **Arun:** Please include that the issue was an unfinished check, not a confirmed routing failure.

19 **Leila:** I will. The [8] _____ will distinguish those. Before we close, any [9] _____ about who does what?

20 **Ben:** No. I'll [10] _____ for the supervisors: schedule ready, routing check due at three, launch decision still with Leila.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** crosstalk / **2.** unverified / **3.** paraphrase / **4.** timebox / **5.** parking lot / **6.** action item / **7.** decision is pending / **8.** decision log / **9.** unresolved question / **10.** recap the next steps

Why these answers fit, page 106

# F Repair the message

## A remote colleague flags a missing translation check

> **New case / facts you can use**
>
> A product demonstration is prepared. Remote reviewer Ines says the Spanish labels have not been checked. Chair Noah must decide whether to release the demonstration. Pavel has prepared the slides; no release has been authorized.

Choose the correction that preserves the supplied facts. Say the complete corrected message aloud.

**1. Repair "Ines wants to delay the demonstration."**

**A.** Ines has a translation preference that does not affect readiness.
**B.** Ines rejects the demonstration and requests a new slide deck.
**C.** Ines reports an unfinished Spanish-label check.
**D.** Ines confirms the labels but prefers a later release.

**2. Which chairing line gives the missed concern a fair hearing?**

**A.** Ines, summarize by email; we already understand the concern.
**B.** Both, discuss it separately; I will release the demonstration now.
**C.** Ines, explain the unchecked labels; Pavel, respond after her.
**D.** Pavel, finish first; Ines can send the result after release.

Answers and explanations, page 107

> **Listen for the distinction**
>
> Use a calm falling tone for "Ines has the floor." Contrast UNCHECKED with WRONG, then pause before naming the next owner.

> **Protect access, not just airtime**
>
> Someone may be quiet because of audio delay, language-processing time, a missed invitation, or uncertainty about the decision. Do not diagnose the reason from silence. Give the remote participant a named turn, stop overlapping speech, and summarize the contribution before moving on. First-name address or an informal manner does not establish that hierarchy has disappeared. The chair still needs to state who decides and whose input is missing.

# F Say it / then change one fact

## A remote colleague flags a missing translation check

A product demonstration is prepared. Remote reviewer Ines says the Spanish labels have not been checked. Chair Noah must decide whether to release the demonstration. Pavel has prepared the slides; no release has been authorized.

Complete the four gaps. With a partner, read alternate roles, then switch. Studying alone, read both roles and pause before each response.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

floor / pending / unchecked / recap

01 **Noah:** Ines has the [1] _____. Pavel, I'll come to you next.

02 **Ines:** The labels are [2] _____, not necessarily wrong.

03 **Pavel:** Understood. I'll send the exact slide version you need.

04 **Noah:** Good. Ines, check that version. The release decision remains [3] _____.

05 **Ines:** I'll report the result, including anything still unresolved.

06 **Noah:** I'll record the result and the decision separately in the [4] _____.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** floor / **2.** unchecked / **3.** pending / **4.** recap

Why these answers fit, page 108

### Second take

Choose the updated response, then say it without looking at the options. Retain every fact in the correct response.

**1. New fact: Ines finds no label errors, but Noah has not decided on release. Choose Pavel's update.**

**A.** The label check is complete; release awaits Noah's decision.

**B.** The label check is complete; no further release decision is needed.

**C.** The label check is complete; Ines has authorized the release.

**D.** The label check is incomplete until Noah approves every label.

Answers and explanations, page 108

LESSON 06 / GIVE SPECIFIC, USEFUL FEEDBACK

# A Read the situation

Describe behavior, explain operational impact, ask about causes, and agree a measurable next step.

**Report handoff / two-week record**

| ITEM | OBSERVED RECORD |
|---|---|
| **Agreed deadline** | Thursday, noon |
| **Week 1 arrival** | Friday morning |
| **Week 2 arrival** | Friday morning |
| **Effect** | Planning deferred a staffing update |
| **Dependency** | Diego needs a source file from another team; cause not yet established |

People: Elena, International department manager; Diego, US-based analyst.

## Read the record

Choose one answer per question using the facts above.

**1. Which opening is supported by the record?**

**A.** The source team caused both delays through negligence.
**B.** Both reports arrived after the Thursday-noon deadline.
**C.** Diego chose to prioritize other work over the report.
**D.** Planning changed its deadline without telling Diego.

**2. Which consequence can Elena describe without adding facts?**

**A.** Diego received a formal disciplinary warning.
**B.** Planning deferred its staffing update.
**C.** The source-team manager ignored a warning.
**D.** A customer contract was lost after the delay.

**3. Which question investigates the missing information?**

**A.** Will you promise never to depend on another team again?
**B.** Can you admit that the source team failed to do its job?
**C.** Why did you ignore the deadline for two consecutive weeks?
**D.** What happened between the source-file handoff and delivery?

Answers and explanations, page 109

# B Vocabulary in use

**CORE TERMS**

### observable behavior
An action that can be described without guessing at motive.

*describe observable behavior*

### attribution
An explanation assigned to someone's behavior or an event.

*check an attribution*

### bottleneck
A point that limits the flow or speed of work.

*remove a bottleneck*

### lead time
The interval needed before an output or action can be ready.

*allow sufficient lead time*

### check-in
A brief conversation to review status or provide support.

*schedule a check-in*

### performance expectation
A clear description of the work standard required.

*clarify a performance expectation*

### impact
The effect of an action on people or work.

*explain the impact*

### pattern
A repeated feature across more than one event.

*identify a pattern*

### upstream input
Information or work required from an earlier stage or another team.

*obtain upstream input*

### corrective action
An agreed step to address a problem or prevent its recurrence.

*agree corrective action*

### follow-through
Carrying out what was agreed, not just agreeing to it.

*demonstrate follow-through*

### SBI
Situation-Behavior-Impact: CCL's sequence for specific feedback.

*use an SBI structure [2]*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**attribution** at-tri-BU-tion

Calling the delay carelessness is an attribution, not an observation.

Describe arrival times before drawing conclusions about motive.

**bottleneck** BOT-tle-neck

The source-file handoff is a possible bottleneck.

Possible cause is not yet established cause.

# B Precision and professional shorthand

EXTEND YOUR RANGE

### coaching

Support that helps someone improve specific work or skills.

*hold a coaching conversation*

### root cause

An underlying cause whose removal can help prevent the problem recurring.

*investigate the root cause*

### early-warning signal

Information showing that a problem may occur before the outcome is final.

*act on an early-warning signal*

### measurable standard

A work requirement whose achievement can be checked against stated evidence.

*set a measurable standard*

### rework

Work that must be done again to correct or accommodate a problem.

*reduce avoidable rework*

### action plan

A record of agreed steps, owners, and completion times.

*agree a focused action plan*

### performance gap

The difference between an agreed standard and observed performance.

*identify a performance gap*

### contributing factor

Something that helps produce an outcome without necessarily being its only cause.

*identify contributing factors*

### recurrence

The return of a problem after an earlier occurrence.

*prevent recurrence*

### timeliness

Delivery within the time required for the work to be useful.

*improve report timeliness*

### support request

A specific request for help, access, or resources.

*make a concrete support request*

### evidence-based feedback

Feedback tied to observable events or reliable records.

*give evidence-based feedback*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**recurrence** re-CUR-rence

An early warning may help prevent recurrence.

Preventing recurrence requires a changed process, not a vague promise.

**follow-through** FOL-low-through

We will check follow-through at the next review.

Follow-through means completing agreed action, not just agreeing to it.

# C Phrases that move the work forward

**Name the occasion**

For each of the last two weekly reports, we agreed on Thursday noon.

**Describe the behavior**

Both reports arrived on Friday morning.

**Explain impact**

Planning had to defer its staffing update while it waited for the figures.

**Ask without assigning motive**

What prevented the Thursday delivery?

**Separate cause from standard**

That explains the delay; we still need an early warning when the input is missing.

**Offer concrete support**

I will speak with the source-team manager about the handoff.

**Set a trigger**

If the file is missing by Wednesday noon, notify me that day.

**Define follow-up**

We will review the next two reports at a short Friday check-in.

**Check the standard**

What deadline did you understand us to have agreed?

**Separate two problems**

We need to address both the late source file and the missing early warning.

**Limit a conclusion**

These two reports show a delivery problem; they do not establish your motivation.

**Explore contributing factors**

Apart from the source file, which steps affected the delivery time?

**Define useful support**

Would an earlier handoff, access to the source owner, or a clearer trigger help most?

**Make improvement measurable**

For the next two reports, we will check the delivery time and whether a warning was sent.

**Recognize a correction**

You flagged the missing file before noon this time; that gave planning time to respond.

**Agree a next step**

Please confirm the action you own and when you will report its status.

## Same purpose, different register

**Observed fact:** Both reports arrived Friday morning.
**Unsupported interpretation:** You do not take the deadline seriously. Avoid presenting this as a fact.

**Concrete support:** I will speak to the source-team manager.
**Specific expectation:** Flag a missing source file by Wednesday at three.

# D Choose the response that fits

Choose one response for each situation. Preserve the facts, the decision boundary, and the purpose of the exchange.

**1. Choose feedback that separates observation from interpretation.**

**A.** The report arrived Friday; I need to understand the delay.

**B.** The report arrived Friday; that shows you do not value planning.

**C.** The report arrived Friday; this means the deadline was unrealistic.

**D.** The report arrived Friday; the source team is clearly at fault.

**2. Which agreement is measurable without pretending Diego controls the source team?**

**A.** Wait until every figure is final before contacting planning again.

**B.** Try to be more proactive and improve coordination when necessary.

**C.** Guarantee the source file arrives Wednesday and the final figures never change.

**D.** Flag a missing file Wednesday at three; send a Thursday-noon status update.

**3. Diego explains a late source file. Which response maintains the standard and investigates cause?**

**A.** That helps explain the delay; let's fix the handoff and warning point.

**B.** That is an excuse; the file arrival cannot affect your deadline.

**C.** That proves the deadline should be canceled for all future reports.

**D.** That removes your responsibility; no further update is needed from you.

**4. Which closing checks action rather than demanding reassurance?**

**A.** At next Thursday's check-in, we will review the file and update times.

**B.** At next Thursday's check-in, confirm that you now care about deadlines.

**C.** At next Thursday's check-in, promise no report will ever arrive late.

**D.** At next Thursday's check-in, agree that the source team owns every delay.

Answers and explanations, page 109

> **One useful distinction**
>
> An impact is an effect you can describe; an attribution is an explanation you assign. Check the explanation before treating it as a fact. A check-in reviews progress; follow-through means carrying out the agreed action.

# E Conversation

## Two late reports and one missing handoff

A private one-to-one meeting after two weekly reports arrived late.

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once; some entries contain several words.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

early-warning signal / follow-through / bottleneck / update / recurrence / rework / performance expectation / upstream input / action plan / impact

01 **Elena:** Have you got ten minutes to look at the last two reports? Both were due Thursday noon and arrived Friday morning.

02 **Diego:** Yes. I know they were late. I was waiting for the source file, and I didn't want to send numbers I couldn't support.

03 **Elena:** I appreciate that. The [1] _____ was that planning had to defer its staffing update. Walk me through the handoff.

04 **Diego:** The source file arrived Thursday afternoon both weeks. I checked it afterward and sent the report the next morning.

05 **Elena:** So the [2] _____ arrived after your deadline. Did anyone know you were still waiting?

06 **Diego:** I asked the source team Wednesday. I didn't tell planning. I expected the file to come through and didn't want to send another warning that went nowhere.

07 **Elena:** That explains the decision. It also leaves planning without an [3] _____. What warning point would actually help?

08 **Diego:** Wednesday at three. If I don't have the file then, I can say what's missing and what it affects.

09 **Elena:** Let's use that. I'll speak with the source-team manager about the [4] _____. You shouldn't have to negotiate their priorities alone.

10 **Diego:** Thanks. I still can't promise a verified Thursday report if the source file turns up late.

Conversation continues on the next page.

# Two late reports and one missing handoff

**CONVERSATION / CONTINUED**

11 **Elena:** Agreed. The [5] _____ is a Thursday-noon report or a clear status update if the input prevents it.

12 **Diego:** With the missing items named, rather than an empty spreadsheet?

13 **Elena:** Yes. State what is confirmed, what is missing, and the next update. That measurable standard is more useful than asking you to "be proactive."

14 **Diego:** That gives me an [6] _____: flag Wednesday at three, send a status [7] _____ Thursday noon, and verify the figures once the file arrives.

15 **Elena:** Right. Let's check it next Thursday. We'll review the actual file-arrival and message times, not just whether everyone felt communication improved.

16 **Diego:** Can we keep the warning in the shared channel? If I message three people separately, the versions drift.

17 **Elena:** Yes. That should reduce [8] _____. Tag planning and me in the same update.

18 **Diego:** I can do that. If the source team fixes its timing, should I stop the Wednesday check?

19 **Elena:** Keep the check for now. We want to see whether this prevents [9] _____, not declare it solved after one good week.

20 **Diego:** Fair. I'll put the times in my calendar, and we can check [10] _____ against the actual record next Thursday.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** impact / **2.** upstream input / **3.** early-warning signal / **4.** bottleneck / **5.** performance expectation / **6.** action plan / **7.** update / **8.** rework / **9.** recurrence / **10.** follow-through

Why these answers fit, page 110

# F Repair the message

## Two missed customer callbacks

### New case / facts you can use

A callback was promised for Tuesday at 4 p.m. and happened Wednesday at 10 a.m. on each of two weeks. Customer updates were delayed. Sal does not yet know why. Jo can control warning messages, not the arrival of every technical answer.

Choose the correction that preserves the supplied facts. Say the complete corrected message aloud.

**1. Repair "You keep ignoring customers."**

**A.** Both customers misunderstood the callback time we promised.
**B.** Both callbacks were delayed because you chose easier work.
**C.** Both callbacks happened Wednesday, after the Tuesday commitment.
**D.** Both callbacks were late, so all technical questions must be resolved Tuesday.

**2. Which request creates an observable early warning?**

**A.** If the answer is missing at three, treat the original promise as canceled.
**B.** If the answer is missing at three, wait until it is complete to contact anyone.
**C.** If the answer is missing at three, send a status message then.
**D.** If the answer is missing at three, guarantee it will arrive by four.

Answers and explanations, page 111

### Listen for the distinction

Read the two arrival times neutrally. Stress the ACTION in the agreement, not the person in the criticism.

### Specific is clearer than severe

Feedback can be direct without making a claim about character. Name the two reports and their effect; then ask what happened. "You lack commitment" guesses at motivation. "The last two reports arrived after our agreed deadline" names an observable pattern. The Center for Creative Leadership's Situation-Behavior-Impact approach informs this distinction [2]. Once a cause is explained, a manager can offer support without quietly removing the deadline.

# F Say it / then change one fact

## Two missed customer callbacks

A callback was promised for Tuesday at 4 p.m. and happened Wednesday at 10 a.m. on each of two weeks. Customer updates were delayed. Sal does not yet know why. Jo can control warning messages, not the arrival of every technical answer.

Complete the four gaps. With a partner, read alternate roles, then switch. Studying alone, read both roles and pause before each response.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

bottleneck / status update / check-in / warning

01 **Sal:** Both callbacks happened Wednesday. What was the [1] _____?

02 **Jo:** I was waiting for technical answers. I should have sent a [2] _____ before four.

03 **Sal:** If the answer is missing at three, send a [3] _____.

04 **Jo:** Even if the technical answer is still pending?

05 **Sal:** Yes. State the next contact time. We'll review the message times at our [4] _____.

06 **Jo:** Understood. I can control that contact even when I can't control the technical answer.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** bottleneck / **2.** warning / **3.** status update / **4.** check-in

Why these answers fit, page 112

### Second take

Choose the updated response, then say it without looking at the options. Retain every fact in the correct response.

**1. New fact: Jo sends the three-o'clock warning, but the technical answer arrives Wednesday. Choose Sal's feedback.**

**A.** The answer was late, so Jo must have ignored the agreed warning point.

**B.** The warning was on time; the technical dependency still needs attention.

**C.** The answer was late, so the warning counts as late as well.

**D.** The warning was on time, so the original customer promise was fully met.

Answers and explanations, page 112

# Review 3 / A quiet voice and a late file

Use language from the lessons you have completed. Choose one answer per question.

> **Case file**
>
> Remote analyst Ava posted that the cost file had not arrived. Nobody responded. The chair summarized her concern as dislike of the schedule. Two previous reports arrived a day late. The file delay is a possible cause, not a confirmed explanation of both incidents.

**1. Which chairing action comes first?**

**A.** Move to the next topic because the file is outside the agenda.
**B.** Ask Ava to agree with the recorded schedule preference.
**C.** Explain that chat messages count as agreement unless marked urgent.
**D.** Give Ava an uninterrupted turn to explain the missing file.

**2. Which wording separates observation from cause?**

**A.** Two reports arrived late; Ava did not care about the deadline.
**B.** Two reports arrived late; we need to trace the handoff.
**C.** Two reports arrived late; the agreed deadline must have changed.
**D.** Two reports arrived late; the source team caused both delays.

**3. Choose the most useful early-warning agreement.**

**A.** If the file is missing, guarantee the source team will finish on time.
**B.** If the file is missing at the agreed checkpoint, send a status update.
**C.** If the file is missing, treat the report deadline as silently canceled.
**D.** If the file is missing, wait until the final report can be completed.

**4. Which correction belongs in the minutes?**

**A.** Ava reported a missing input; the cause of past delays remains under review.
**B.** Ava disliked the schedule; the file was the confirmed cause of both delays.
**C.** Ava withdrew her concern; the chair considers both delays resolved.
**D.** Ava approved the schedule; the missing file no longer affects the report.

Answers and explanations, page 123

LESSON 07 / COORDINATE ACROSS OFFICES

# A Read the situation

Negotiate a reporting interface, translate local constraints, and define exceptions without weakening oversight.

**Branch reporting / request and workload**

| ITEM | CURRENT SITUATION |
|---|---|
| **Request** | Re-enter 18 figures in a daily spreadsheet |
| **Existing record** | Most figures already in the shared dashboard |
| **Manual effort** | 1 hour per day |
| **HQ purpose** | Early warning of service failures |
| **Authority** | Nadia and Ren may change this internal process, not separate mandatory reports |

People: Nadia, International manager of a US branch; Ren, Headquarters operations manager.

## Read the record

Choose one answer per question using the facts above.

**1. What does Ren need the information to support?**

**A.** Proof that the branch is busy enough each day.
**B.** Early warning of service failures.
**C.** A second permanent archive of every dashboard figure.
**D.** Approval to remove all mandatory reporting.

**2. Which proposed change falls within the supplied authority?**

**A.** Agree a new format for this internal service update.
**B.** Stop monitoring service levels once the spreadsheet is removed.
**C.** End every mandatory report that duplicates a dashboard field.
**D.** Treat unreported dashboard fields as confirmed service failures.

**3. Which fact best explains the branch's workload concern?**

**A.** All eighteen figures are absent from the shared dashboard.
**B.** The branch has permission to ignore headquarters requests.
**C.** Headquarters distrusts every figure the branch supplies.
**D.** Re-entering the figures takes one hour per day.

Answers and explanations, page 113

# B Vocabulary in use

**CORE TERMS**

### reporting cadence
How often a report or update is provided.

*agree a reporting cadence*

### exception reporting
Reporting deviations from agreed conditions rather than every routine item.

*use exception reporting*

### threshold
A defined point that triggers attention or action.

*set an alert threshold*

### single source of truth
The agreed authoritative record for a particular set of information.

*maintain a single source of truth*

### duplicate entry
Recording the same information again in another place.

*eliminate duplicate entry*

### audit trail
A record that shows changes, actions, or supporting evidence.

*preserve an audit trail*

### visibility
Access to information needed to understand a situation.

*maintain visibility*

### local context
Conditions specific to the branch or operating environment.

*explain the local context*

### handoff
Transfer of information or responsibility between people or teams.

*clarify the handoff*

### service level
An agreed or defined standard of service performance.

*monitor the service level*

### reporting burden
The time and effort required to prepare and maintain reports.

*reduce the reporting burden*

### escalation path
The agreed route for bringing an issue to the right authority.

*follow the escalation path*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**cadence** CA-dence

Let's agree a reporting cadence that matches the decision.

Cadence is frequency, not the reporting deadline itself.

**threshold** THRESH-old

A threshold needs a defined trigger, not "when things look bad."

Crossing a threshold triggers action; it does not explain the cause.

# B Precision and professional shorthand

**EXTEND YOUR RANGE**

### reporting line

The management relationship showing whom a person reports to.

*clarify the reporting line*

### reporting period

The span of time covered by a report.

*specify the reporting period*

### data lineage

The history of where data came from and how it was transformed.

*trace the data lineage*

### data completeness

The extent to which the required information is present.

*check data completeness*

### operating model

The arrangement of roles, processes, and decision rights used to run the work.

*align the operating model*

### cross-functional dependency

Work in one function that depends on an input or decision from another.

*manage a cross-functional dependency*

### data owner

The role answerable for a defined set of data and its use or maintenance.

*identify the data owner*

### refresh cycle

How often information is updated in a system or report.

*confirm the refresh cycle*

### version control

A method for identifying versions and tracking changes to a record.

*maintain version control*

### acknowledgment time

The agreed time within which a receiver confirms receipt.

*set an acknowledgment time*

### local discretion

The choices a branch or local team may make within shared requirements.

*define local discretion*

### information requirement

The specific information needed for a stated purpose.

*clarify the information requirement*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**data lineage** DA-ta LIN-e-age

The note preserves the data lineage for the corrected figure.

Lineage tracks origin and transformation, not just the newest value.

**exception reporting** ex-CEP-tion re-PORT-ing

Exception reporting highlights departures from an agreed rule.

It still requires routine monitoring of the underlying data.

# C Phrases that move the work forward

**Ask about use**

Which decision does each daily figure support?

**Preserve the purpose**

I want to reduce duplication, not reduce your visibility.

**Define an exception**

An exception means a missed service target or an unassigned urgent case.

**Agree a handoff**

The branch duty lead will send the alert and name the action owner.

**Check data freshness**

As of what time are these figures current?

**Name the source**

Which record should both offices use if the spreadsheet and dashboard disagree?

**Set a response expectation**

Please confirm receipt by the agreed acknowledgment time, even if the issue is unresolved.

**Define time precisely**

Does the reporting period end at midnight in New York or at headquarters?

**Quantify the burden**

Re-entering the eighteen figures takes one hour each day.

**Offer a reporting design**

Could we use the dashboard for routine figures and a separate alert for exceptions?

**Protect authority**

This proposal does not change any separate mandatory report.

**Test the arrangement**

Let us trial the format for two weeks and review missed alerts and preparation time.

**Distinguish reporting terms**

The reporting line tells us who manages the analyst; the cadence tells us when updates arrive.

**Locate a change**

Can we trace that revised figure to its source and see when it changed?

**Clarify local flexibility**

Which parts of the format may the branch adapt without changing the shared requirement?

**Close a cross-office gap**

Let us name an owner on each side of the handoff, including cover for absences.

## Same purpose, different register

**Branch concern:** We spend an hour retyping figures you can already see.
**Shared objective:** We want reliable early warning with less duplicate entry.

**Technical label:** Exception reporting
**Plain-language explanation:** Send an alert when the agreed service threshold is crossed.

# D Choose the response that fits

Choose one response for each situation. Preserve the facts, the decision boundary, and the purpose of the exchange.

**1. Which opening translates the disagreement into a shared problem?**

**A.** Why does headquarters need so much reassurance from the branch?
**B.** Would a shorter spreadsheet prove that the branch is cooperative?
**C.** What decision needs an alert, and which figures support it?
**D.** Can we stop all reporting now that the dashboard is available?

**2. Which description makes exception reporting operational?**

**A.** Monitor routinely; treat every missing update as a confirmed failure.
**B.** Monitor occasionally; alert Ren whenever the branch feels concerned.
**C.** Monitor routinely; alert Ren when the agreed trigger is met.
**D.** Stop monitoring; send an alert if a customer discovers a problem.

**3. Which sentence protects the scope of the process change?**

**A.** This changes the internal update, not any separate mandatory report.
**B.** This removes all reporting that overlaps with the dashboard.
**C.** This ends the need to record corrections to shared figures.
**D.** This makes the dashboard owner responsible for all office decisions.

**4. Ren worries about losing visibility. Which reply addresses that concern?**

**A.** Keep dashboard access and agree an alert owner and response time.
**B.** Keep dashboard access and assume silence means all checks passed.
**C.** Keep dashboard access but remove the branch from alert ownership.
**D.** Keep dashboard access and postpone all exceptions to the monthly meeting.

Answers and explanations, page 113

> **One useful distinction**
>
> An exception is an event outside a defined condition, not anything someone dislikes. A threshold triggers an action; a cadence sets its rhythm. An audit trail preserves the history rather than replacing it with the latest number.

# E Conversation

## One report, two different purposes

A process-design call between a US branch and a headquarters operations team.

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once; some entries contain several words.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

refresh cycle / single source of truth / threshold / acknowledgment time / escalation path / exception reporting / reporting cadence / audit trail / duplicate entry / information requirement

01 **Ren:** Can the branch put the eighteen figures into the daily spreadsheet again? I didn't have a clear picture at yesterday's review.

02 **Nadia:** Can we start with the decision you needed to make? Most of those figures are already on the dashboard. The [1] _____ takes us an hour a day.

03 **Ren:** I need to know when service is slipping, before a director asks me. Opening a dashboard doesn't tell me what changed overnight.

04 **Nadia:** So it's early warning, not another archive. I can work with that [2] _____ .

05 **Ren:** Yes, but I don't want a lighter process that leaves headquarters guessing whether no news means no problem.

06 **Nadia:** Neither do I. We could keep routine monitoring and use [3] _____ for the agreed service triggers.

07 **Ren:** What counts as an exception? Different teams have been using that word differently.

08 **Nadia:** Let's define the [4] _____ together before we start. The service owner needs to confirm which measures and limits are appropriate.

09 **Ren:** And who sends the alert? Last month everyone assumed someone else had sent it.

10 **Nadia:** Name a branch owner and a backup in the process card. Give headquarters an [5] _____ so we know the message reached somebody.

Conversation continues on the next page.

# One report, two different purposes

**CONVERSATION / CONTINUED**

11 **Ren:** That helps. The dashboard refreshed late yesterday, though. I was looking at old figures without realizing it.

12 **Nadia:** Then the [6] _____ needs to be visible. We'll show the update time, and an alert will say when its source data was captured.

13 **Ren:** Can the dashboard stay the authoritative record? I don't want three different totals circulating.

14 **Nadia:** Yes. Keep one [7] _____. The alert should link to the record, not create a new spreadsheet total.

15 **Ren:** What about corrections? If a figure changes, I need to know which version I used in the review.

16 **Nadia:** We'll preserve the [8] _____. Removing re-entry doesn't mean erasing revisions.

17 **Ren:** All right. Propose a reporting frequency and the alert route. We can test whether I get the early warning I need.

18 **Nadia:** I'll send a proposed [9] _____ and the owners. Separate mandatory reports stay unchanged.

19 **Ren:** Agreed. This is a change to our internal update, not permission to stop other reporting. Let's review the trial after two weeks.

20 **Nadia:** I'll include that review and the [10] _____. The aim is less retyping, not less visibility.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** duplicate entry / **2.** information requirement / **3.** exception reporting / **4.** threshold / **5.** acknowledgment time / **6.** refresh cycle / **7.** single source of truth / **8.** audit trail / **9.** reporting cadence / **10.** escalation path

Why these answers fit, page 114

# F Repair the message

## A daily slide deck that repeats the ticket system

### New case / facts you can use

A support team spends 40 minutes daily copying ticket counts into slides. The regional lead needs immediate notice of a missed service target. The ticket system remains the authoritative record. Separate required reports remain unchanged.

Choose the correction that preserves the supplied facts. Say the complete corrected message aloud.

**1. Repair "No slides means no more reporting."**

**A.** Routine monitoring ends; customer complaints will trigger the next report.
**B.** Routine slides continue; all other required reports can now stop.
**C.** Routine monitoring continues; missing alerts prove every target was met.
**D.** Routine monitoring continues; alerts replace duplicate slide entry.

**2. Which process detail is needed before the change starts?**

**A.** The alert trigger, sender, recipient, and response expectation.
**B.** The permission to replace all required reports with informal messages.
**C.** The assumption that every manager checks the system continuously.
**D.** The slide colors, font size, logo position, and picture choice.

Answers and explanations, page 115

### Listen for the distinction

Contrast LESS RETYPING with LESS VISIBILITY. Explain "authoritative record" once, then use the plain label "ticket system."

### Translate the business need

Headquarters may experience fewer updates as loss of visibility; a branch may experience repeated requests as distrust. Neither interpretation is established by the request alone. Ask what decision the information supports, then propose a format that serves it. Explain the local workload in measurable terms. Avoid describing one office as "bureaucratic" or the other as "uncooperative" when the real disagreement concerns frequency, evidence, and responsibility.

# F Say it / then change one fact

## A daily slide deck that repeats the ticket system

A support team spends 40 minutes daily copying ticket counts into slides. The regional lead needs immediate notice of a missed service target. The ticket system remains the authoritative record. Separate required reports remain unchanged.

Complete the four gaps. With a partner, read alternate roles, then switch. Studying alone, read both roles and pause before each response.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

unchanged / receipt / authoritative record / trigger

01 **Rae:** The ticket system stays the [1] _____.

02 **Lin:** Then I need an alert when the agreed [2] _____ is met.

03 **Rae:** We'll name the sender and backup. Who confirms [3] _____ on your side?

04 **Lin:** I do, with my deputy covering absences.

05 **Rae:** Good. We'll record that and leave the separate required reports [4] _____.

06 **Lin:** Agreed. Let's review whether alerts arrive in time, not just whether the slides disappeared.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** authoritative record / **2.** trigger / **3.** receipt / **4.** unchanged

Why these answers fit, page 116

### Second take

Choose the updated response, then say it without looking at the options. Retain every fact in the correct response.

**1. New fact: an alert is sent, but neither Lin nor the deputy acknowledges it within the agreed time. Choose Rae's next step.**

**A.** Delete the original alert and wait for the monthly review.

**B.** Use the agreed escalation route and preserve the alert record.

**C.** Treat the missing reply as permission to stop monitoring targets.

**D.** Assume the issue is resolved because the message was delivered.

Answers and explanations, page 116

LESSON 08 / REPAIR MISUNDERSTANDINGS AND BUILD TRUST

# A Read the situation

Acknowledge a specific impact, separate intent from effect, repair the record, and agree a verifiable change.

**Meeting record / correction needed**

| OBSERVED EVENT | RECORD NEEDING REPAIR |
|---|---|
| **Daniel interrupted Lena twice** | Her explanation of customer risk was unfinished |
| **Minutes describe a timing preference** | Lena had raised a customer risk |
| **Lena reports feeling dismissed** | Daniel has not yet corrected the shared record |
| **Business issue** | Risk remains unresolved; no outcome promised |

People: Daniel, International project manager; Lena, US-based risk analyst.

## Read the record

Choose one answer per question using the facts above.

**1. What must the corrected record preserve?**

**A.** Daniel resolved the customer risk before Lena spoke.
**B.** The project decision must now favor Lena's recommendation.
**C.** Lena approved the launch but disliked the meeting time.
**D.** Lena raised a customer risk, not a timing preference.

**2. Which action is Daniel in a position to promise?**

**A.** Correct the minutes and give the concern a full hearing.
**B.** Guarantee approval of Lena's preferred project option.
**C.** Guarantee that no customer risk will materialize later.
**D.** Guarantee Lena will feel reassured by the next meeting.

**3. Which statement acknowledges an action rather than disputing its impact?**

**A.** I think we both contributed equally to the confusion in the minutes.
**B.** I interrupted because the meeting needed a more positive tone.
**C.** I am sorry if you took my efforts to help in the wrong way.
**D.** I interrupted you twice and left your risk explanation unfinished.

Answers and explanations, page 117

# B Vocabulary in use

**CORE TERMS**

### acknowledge
Recognize an action, fact, or experience explicitly.

*acknowledge the impact*

### impact
What an action actually did or how it affected someone.

*separate intent from impact*

### repair
An action that addresses a communication or relationship failure.

*make a concrete repair*

### correction
A change that makes a record or statement accurate.

*circulate a correction*

### good faith
An honest effort to engage rather than mislead or obstruct.

*act in good faith*

### follow-up
Later action to check or continue an agreed step.

*set a follow-up*

### intent
What someone meant or hoped to accomplish.

*explain an intent*

### defensiveness
Responding mainly to protect oneself from criticism.

*reduce defensiveness*

### retraction
Withdrawal of a statement that should no longer stand.

*issue a retraction*

### mischaracterize
Describe someone's position inaccurately or unfairly.

*mischaracterize a concern*

### commitment
An undertaking to do something specific.

*make a limited commitment*

### working agreement
Explicit expectations for how people will cooperate.

*establish a working agreement*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**mischaracterize** mis-CHAR-ac-ter-ize

I mischaracterized your risk concern as a preference.

Naming the inaccurate description is stronger than saying there was confusion.

**retraction** re-TRAC-tion

I will issue a retraction of the unsupported claim.

Retract withdraws a claim; clarify may merely explain it.

# B Precision and professional shorthand

EXTEND YOUR RANGE

### ownership

Acceptance that an action or problem is yours to address.

*take ownership of the mistake*

### attribution of credit

Identification of the person whose contribution is being recognized.

*ensure accurate attribution of credit*

### de-escalation

Reducing the intensity of a conflict without necessarily resolving the issue.

*support de-escalation*

### reciprocity

A pattern of responding to another person's constructive action with one of your own.

*build reciprocity over time*

### corroboration

Additional evidence that supports an account of what happened.

*seek corroboration of the account*

### reputational harm

Damage to how others judge a person's competence or reliability.

*address reputational harm*

### omission

Something important left out of a statement or record.

*correct an omission*

### intent-impact gap

The difference between an intended effect and what actually happened.

*address the intent-impact gap*

### face-saving

Allowing someone to preserve dignity while a mistake is addressed.

*offer a face-saving correction*

### remedy

An action intended to put a specific problem right.

*agree a proportionate remedy*

### non-defensive response

A reply that engages with criticism without immediately protecting or excusing oneself.

*give a non-defensive response*

### procedural fairness

Fairness in how views are heard and a decision is reached.

*protect procedural fairness*

## Say it in context

Capitals show the stressed syllable, not a full pronunciation spelling.

**defensiveness** de-FEN-sive-ness

An excuse at the start can sound like defensiveness.

Explaining intent does not erase an action's effect.

**procedural fairness** pro-CE-dur-al FAIR-ness

An uninterrupted review protects procedural fairness.

A fair hearing does not guarantee a preferred decision.

# C Phrases that move the work forward

**Own the action**

I interrupted you twice and summarized your concern inaccurately.

**Apologize directly**

I am sorry I cut you off.

**Acknowledge the effect**

You did not get a fair chance to explain the customer risk.

**Explain without excusing**

I was trying to manage time; that does not justify misrepresenting your point.

**Correct the record**

I will send a correction to everyone who received the original summary.

**Make a process commitment**

You will have an uninterrupted turn before we decide.

**Avoid a false outcome promise**

I cannot promise agreement, but I can promise an accurate review.

**Check the repair**

After the next meeting, we will check whether the new turn-taking rule was followed.

**Own an omission**

I left your contribution out of the summary, and I will correct that.

**Restore credit**

The revised note will name your contribution and link to the original proposal.

**Invite a factual correction**

Which part of my account is still inaccurate?

**Avoid requesting reassurance**

You do not need to tell me that everything is fine today.

**Preserve dignity and accuracy**

We can correct the record without making another personal judgment.

**Acknowledge remaining disagreement**

Correcting my account does not require us to agree on the recommendation.

**Set a verifiable remedy**

I will send the correction to the original recipients by this afternoon.

**Allow trust to develop**

I understand that trust will depend on what I do in the next meeting.

## Same purpose, different register

**Own the action:** I cut you off twice and recorded your point incorrectly.
**Avoid distancing language:** There seems to have been a misunderstanding. This leaves the actor unnamed.

**Concrete repair:** I will correct the minutes in the same group.
**Bounded commitment:** I will give the risk a full hearing, not promise a predetermined decision.

# D Choose the response that fits

Choose one response for each situation. Preserve the facts, the decision boundary, and the purpose of the exchange.

**1. Choose the strongest opening repair.**

**A.** I cut you off twice, and I recorded your concern incorrectly.
**B.** I am sorry, but we had agreed to keep the discussion positive.
**C.** I am sorry if the meeting format caused some misunderstanding.
**D.** I am sorry you felt cut off while I was trying to help.

**2. Which correction addresses the original audience?**

**A.** Send a new schedule without mentioning the earlier risk description.
**B.** Send a general reminder that everyone should communicate more clearly.
**C.** Send the corrected risk description to the same meeting group.
**D.** Send Lena a private apology and leave the shared minutes unchanged.

**3. Lena is not ready to reassure Daniel. Which response respects that?**

**A.** You do not need to settle this now; I will wait to correct the record.
**B.** You do not need to settle this now; I will make the correction today.
**C.** You do not need to settle this now; please confirm we are fine before leaving.
**D.** You do not need to settle this now; the apology should close the issue.

**4. Which promise protects a fair process without fixing the outcome?**

**A.** I will approve your recommendation to show that the apology is sincere.
**B.** I will remove the risk from the record to avoid further discomfort.
**C.** I will describe the risk as resolved so the team can move forward.
**D.** I will hear the risk fully before we make the project decision.

Answers and explanations, page 117

> **One useful distinction**
>
> An explanation describes why something happened; it does not automatically excuse the impact. A correction replaces inaccurate information, while a retraction withdraws a statement. Follow-up checks progress; follow-through carries out the promise.

# E Conversation

## An apology that changes the next meeting

A private conversation after a tense project meeting.

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once; some entries contain several words.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

trust / intent / process commitment / a full hearing / mischaracterized / circulate / acknowledge / follow-up / working agreement / ownership

01 **Daniel:** Could we talk about yesterday's review? I cut you off twice, and the minutes describe your risk concern as a preference about timing. That was wrong.

02 **Lena:** Yes. It felt as if you'd decided what I meant before I'd finished. Then the record made it look like I was just asking for more time.

03 **Daniel:** I [1] _____ your point. I was watching the clock, but that doesn't make the summary accurate.

04 **Lena:** The time pressure was real. So was the customer risk. We can't fix the second one by apologizing for the first.

05 **Daniel:** Agreed. I want to [2] _____ the impact and correct the record. I won't pretend that settles the risk.

06 **Lena:** What would you change in the minutes?

07 **Daniel:** I'd withdraw the "timing preference" line and replace it with your actual concern. Can you check the wording before I [3] _____ it?

08 **Lena:** I can. But it needs to go to the same group. A private note to me won't change what they think I said.

09 **Daniel:** Yes. I'll take [4] _____ of the error in that message. I won't make it sound as if you changed your position afterward.

10 **Lena:** Thank you. And I need enough time to explain the risk at the next review, without being asked to fit it into the last thirty seconds.

Conversation continues on the next page.

# An apology that changes the next meeting

**CONVERSATION / CONTINUED**

11 **Daniel:** I'll put it first and protect your turn. That's a [5] _____, not a promise that the project decision will go your way.

12 **Lena:** I understand. I'm not asking you to approve my recommendation because the meeting went badly. I'm asking for the evidence to be heard.

13 **Daniel:** Then let's make that our [6] _____: you finish the explanation; I check my summary with you before we decide.

14 **Lena:** And if there's a real time limit, tell me at the start. I can prioritize the key facts instead of getting cut off halfway through.

15 **Daniel:** That's fair. My [7] _____ was to keep the meeting moving. The effect was that your concern disappeared from the record.

16 **Lena:** It did. I appreciate you saying that. I'm still frustrated, though.

17 **Daniel:** You don't have to reassure me. I'll send the correction today. We can have a brief [8] _____ after the next review to see whether the new approach worked.

18 **Lena:** All right. Send me the wording first, and I'll check whether it captures the risk rather than just the delay.

19 **Daniel:** I will. The remedy is an accurate record and [9] _____. Neither requires you to say everything is fine today.

20 **Lena:** That's enough for now. Let's deal with the risk properly and rebuild [10] _____ through what happens next.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** mischaracterized / **2.** acknowledge / **3.** circulate / **4.** ownership / **5.** process commitment / **6.** working agreement / **7.** intent / **8.** follow-up / **9.** a full hearing / **10.** trust

Why these answers fit, page 118

# F Repair the message

## A contributor was left out of an executive update

### New case / facts you can use

Mara presented an accurate result but omitted Chen's analysis from the credits. Executives have not yet forwarded the update. Mara can correct the attribution today; she cannot promise a promotion or Chen's immediate reassurance.

Choose the correction that preserves the supplied facts. Say the complete corrected message aloud.

**1. Repair "I am sorry if you wanted more attention."**

**A.** I omitted your name, so I will guarantee your promotion this month.
**B.** I omitted your name, but everyone probably knew you contributed.
**C.** I omitted your analysis from the credits; I will correct that today.
**D.** I omitted your name because the executives prefer short presentations.

**2. Which follow-up repairs the specific record?**

**A.** Promise to mention someone else's work at a future presentation.
**B.** Send executives the revised credits before they forward the update.
**C.** Withdraw the accurate result so no one can use the presentation.
**D.** Ask Chen to tell the executives privately if recognition matters to him.

Answers and explanations, page 119

### Listen for the distinction

Stress "I omitted" rather than "you wanted." Make a small pause before the promised correction, and avoid rushing the other person toward reassurance.

### An explanation is not an eraser

"I was trying to keep us on time" can explain an intention, but it does not undo an interruption or an inaccurate record. Start with what you did and the effect reported by the other person. Then state a concrete repair. The person receiving the apology does not owe instant reassurance. Disagreement about the project may remain after the relationship improves. A useful repair changes the process without promising a predetermined business decision.

# F Say it / then change one fact

## A contributor was left out of an executive update

Mara presented an accurate result but omitted Chen's analysis from the credits. Executives have not yet forwarded the update. Mara can correct the attribution today; she cannot promise a promotion or Chen's immediate reassurance.

Complete the four gaps. With a partner, read alternate roles, then switch. Studying alone, read both roles and pause before each response.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

omission / correction / attribution / revised record

01 **Mara:** The result was accurate, but the [1] _____ was incomplete.

02 **Chen:** Yes. The executives won't know which analysis came from me.

03 **Mara:** I'll send a [2] _____ today, before they forward it.

04 **Chen:** Please name the analysis, not just "thanks to the team."

05 **Mara:** I will. That's the specific [3] _____ I need to repair.

06 **Chen:** Thank you. Let's check the [4] _____ before it goes out.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** attribution / **2.** correction / **3.** omission / **4.** revised record

Why these answers fit, page 120

### Second take

Choose the updated response, then say it without looking at the options. Retain every fact in the correct response.

**1. New fact: the credits are corrected, but Chen remains upset. Choose Mara's response.**

**A.** The correction is done, so please confirm I did nothing wrong.

**B.** The correction is done, so your promotion is now guaranteed.

**C.** The correction is done, so the matter is closed for you too.

**D.** The correction is done; you do not need to reassure me now.

Answers and explanations, page 120

# Review 4 / The shared dashboard dispute

Use language from the lessons you have completed. Choose one answer per question.

> **Case file**
>
> A branch proposes replacing duplicate slides with alerts from a shared dashboard. The headquarters lead interrupts the branch analyst and records the proposal as "stop monitoring." In fact, monitoring would continue, alerts need agreed triggers, and mandatory reports stay unchanged.

**1. Which correction accurately states the proposal?**

**A.** Retain monitoring; replace duplicate slides with defined alerts.
**B.** Retain slides; remove all separate mandatory reports.
**C.** Remove alerts; treat silence as proof that performance is normal.
**D.** Remove monitoring; rely on customers to report exceptions.

**2. Which apology owns the specific error?**

**A.** I interrupted you and recorded your proposal incorrectly.
**B.** I am sorry if your proposal was difficult for us to follow.
**C.** I am sorry the dashboard caused an unfortunate misunderstanding.
**D.** I am sorry, but headquarters needs stronger cooperation.

**3. Which agreement must precede the alert trial?**

**A.** Eliminate separate mandatory reports to compensate for the interruption.
**B.** Define triggers, owners, acknowledgment times, and an escalation route.
**C.** Assume the dashboard is always current and alerts are never missed.
**D.** Approve the trial because an apology creates agreement on the process.

**4. Which promise repairs the process without predetermining the result?**

**A.** Require the analyst to say trust is restored before reopening the issue.
**B.** Approve the proposal immediately to prove the apology is sincere.
**C.** Correct the record and review the proposal on its actual merits.
**D.** Keep the original minutes so that no one loses face publicly.

Answers and explanations, page 124

# Conversation

## Two urgent launches and six analyst-days

Mina has six analyst-days of capacity available across the team next week. The renewal review needs four; the full launch analysis needs four. A two-day first pass can cover the two largest customer groups but not the regional breakdown. Director Alex can change priorities, but no extra staffing is approved.

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once; some entries contain several words.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

reprioritize / sign-off / trade-off / reopen / point of contact / first pass

01 **Alex:** Can your team add the launch analysis next week? Sales needs it by Friday.

02 **Mina:** We can take it on if we [1] _____. Which deliverable should move?

03 **Alex:** I wasn't asking you to move anything. The renewal review still matters.

04 **Mina:** Together they need eight analyst-days. We have six across the team, even with me taking over the presentation. What should move?

05 **Alex:** Could the team just push a little harder?

06 **Mina:** We are already covering an absence. I can check the estimate, but I will not promise eight analyst-days from six available.

07 **Alex:** All right. What's the smallest useful launch analysis?

08 **Mina:** A two-day [2] _____ covering our two largest customer groups. It would exclude the regional breakdown.

09 **Alex:** Sales will ask for that breakdown immediately.

10 **Mina:** Then we need to choose. I recommend protecting the renewal review and sending the smaller launch analysis on Friday.

Conversation continues on the next page.

# Two urgent launches and six analyst-days

**CONVERSATION / CONTINUED**

11 **Alex:** Why put renewals first?

12 **Mina:** Three contracts come up for review Monday. The launch decision is still two weeks away. That's the [3] _____.

13 **Alex:** That makes sense. Can you promise the rest by Tuesday?

14 **Mina:** I can commit to a scheduling update Tuesday. I need to scope the regional breakdown before I can give you a completion date.

15 **Alex:** Then send the update Tuesday. I need you to explain the reduced Friday scope to Sales today.

16 **Mina:** I will. Can I say we have your [4] _____ on the reduced Friday scope?

17 **Alex:** Yes. Copy me on the message, and I'll back the decision if they challenge it.

18 **Mina:** Thanks. I'll send the scope and dates today. If a new request comes in, we'll [5] _____ the priority discussion.

19 **Alex:** Agreed. I do not want individual analysts negotiating a new scope with Sales on their own.

20 **Mina:** Neither do I. I will be the [6] _____ for changes, and the analysts can focus on the agreed work.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** reprioritize / **2.** first pass / **3.** trade-off / **4.** sign-off / **5.** reopen / **6.** point of contact

Why these answers fit, page 125

# A request arrives after the agreement

Sales requests a third customer group in Friday's first pass. It fits only if it replaces one of the original two. Alex must choose; Mina cannot add work silently.

Complete the exchange using each phrase once. Read both roles, then switch roles and repeat with the bank covered.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

outside the agreed scope / within the same capacity / subject to a new decision / separate from the full analysis

01 **Mina:** A third customer group is [1] _____.

02 **Alex:** Can it fit if we replace one of the first two groups?

03 **Mina:** Yes. Substitution is [2] _____.

04 **Alex:** Keep the original two groups. A third-group request remains [3] _____.

05 **Mina:** I'll tell Sales. Friday's first pass is [4] _____.

06 **Alex:** Good. Send the scheduling update Tuesday; don't invent a completion date for the rest.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** outside the agreed scope / **2.** within the same capacity / **3.** subject to a new decision / **4.** separate from the full analysis

Why these answers fit, page 125

### Keep the boundary audible

Contrast adding a group with replacing one. Name the reduced Friday deliverable separately from the full analysis. Tuesday is a scheduling update, not a promised completion date.

# Conversation

## When praise leaves out the people who did the work

A project sponsor praised a manager for an improved onboarding process. Three team members designed and tested it. The manager accepted the praise without naming them; a team lead raises the omission privately.

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once; some entries contain several words.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

follow-up / omission / attribution / spotlight / routine / take credit

01 **Sam:** Do you have five minutes about the sponsor's update?

02 **Elena:** Sure. I thought it went well. Was something inaccurate?

03 **Sam:** The results were right. But when she thanked you for designing the process, you didn't mention Noor, Luis, or Priya.

04 **Elena:** I didn't mean to [1] _____ for their work. I thought everyone knew it was a team effort.

05 **Sam:** The sponsor doesn't work with them. They heard the update and felt their contribution had disappeared.

06 **Elena:** Thanks for telling me. What would put that right without making the next meeting awkward?

07 **Sam:** A short [2] _____ naming what each person did would help.

08 **Elena:** I can do that. Noor built the checklist, Luis ran the trial, and Priya gathered feedback. Have I got that right?

09 **Sam:** Yes. And Luis also trained the first group of supervisors.

10 **Elena:** I'll include that. I'd like to give them the floor at next month's review.

Conversation continues on the next page.

# When praise leaves out the people who did the work

**CONVERSATION / CONTINUED**

11 **Sam:** Please ask them first. Priya would rather share the customer findings with Noor than present alone.

12 **Elena:** Fair point. Recognition shouldn't become an unexpected [3] _____.

13 **Sam:** Exactly. I don't want us to assume everyone wants the same kind of praise.

14 **Elena:** Would you check whether they'd prefer to present together?

15 **Sam:** I can ask, but the invitation should come from you. That will make the [4] _____ clearer.

16 **Elena:** You're right. I'll send the correction today and speak with them tomorrow.

17 **Sam:** Thank you. I worried this might sound like a complaint about you personally.

18 **Elena:** You raised a specific [5] _____. I needed to hear it.

19 **Sam:** Then let's add contributors' names to future project updates before they go out.

20 **Elena:** Agreed. I'll own the final check and make that part of our [6] _____.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** take credit / **2.** follow-up / **3.** spotlight / **4.** attribution / **5.** omission / **6.** routine

Why these answers fit, page 126

# Correcting the public record

Elena calls the sponsor before sending a written correction. The sponsor has not yet shared the results with the executive team.

Complete the exchange using each phrase once. Read both roles, then switch roles and repeat with the bank covered.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

incomplete as written / explicitly attributed / accurate as reported / needed before circulation

01 **Elena:** The numerical results are [1] _____.

02 **Sponsor:** Then what needs changing before I forward the update?

03 **Elena:** The credits are [2] _____. Noor built the checklist; Luis ran the trial and trained supervisors; Priya gathered feedback.

04 **Sponsor:** I'll use a version with those contributions [3] _____.

05 **Elena:** Thank you. That correction is [4] _____.

06 **Sponsor:** Send it today. I'll hold the update until it is corrected.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** accurate as reported / **2.** incomplete as written / **3.** explicitly attributed / **4.** needed before circulation

Why these answers fit, page 126

### Keep the boundary audible

Separate accurate results from incomplete credit. Name each person's contribution. Do not make public praise a condition of receiving proper attribution.

# Conversation

## Reversing a decision without undermining the team

A branch manager approved a Monday software launch. A test completed Thursday reveals that customers cannot retrieve some older records. The technical lead recommends postponement. Customer messages are prepared but have not been sent.

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once; some entries contain several words.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

release criteria / narrow down / invalidate / hold off / decision point / make the call

01 **Omar:** You asked to revisit Monday. What's changed since yesterday?

02 **Grace:** The archive test failed. Current records load correctly, but some older records don't. We need to [1] _____ on the launch.

03 **Omar:** I told the leadership team the date was settled.

04 **Grace:** I know. We didn't have this result then. I'm asking you to change the decision because the evidence changed.

05 **Omar:** Could we launch and warn customers about older records?

06 **Grace:** Some use those records to complete daily work. Support doesn't have a reliable workaround yet.

07 **Omar:** How long will the fix take?

08 **Grace:** I can't give you that date today. By tomorrow noon, we can [2] _____ the cause and estimate the repair.

09 **Omar:** Then I need a message today that doesn't sound as though the team missed an obvious check.

10 **Grace:** We can state when the test ran and what it found. The test was scheduled before release for this reason.

Conversation continues on the next page.

# Reversing a decision without undermining the team

**CONVERSATION / CONTINUED**

11 **Omar:** You're right. I shouldn't turn this into a search for someone to blame.

12 **Grace:** The immediate [3] _____ is whether to send the launch messages.

13 **Omar:** Don't send them. I'll explain the postponement to leadership myself.

14 **Grace:** Thank you. Can we keep the completed training and documentation work?

15 **Omar:** Yes. This doesn't [4] _____ those deliverables. Update only what the fix changes.

16 **Grace:** I'll tell the team that. They're likely to hear postponement as starting again.

17 **Omar:** Let's be explicit: the release is paused, not abandoned. What will you bring tomorrow?

18 **Grace:** The cause we can support, the repair estimate, and the [5] _____ we still need to satisfy.

19 **Omar:** Good. I'll book the review and explain that the next date depends on those checks.

20 **Grace:** I'll send the evidence first so we can use the meeting to [6] _____, not reconstruct the timeline.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** hold off / **2.** narrow down / **3.** decision point / **4.** invalidate / **5.** release criteria / **6.** make the call

Why these answers fit, page 127

# A colleague asks whether everything is cancelled

A supervisor has heard about the postponement and wants to cancel the training records and support preparation.

Complete the exchange using each phrase once. Read both roles, then switch roles and repeat with the bank covered.

**WORD AND PHRASE BANK**

still usable / not yet confirmed / temporarily paused / dependent on the repair

01 **Supervisor:** Do I cancel the training records and support preparation?

02 **Omar:** No. The release is [1] _____.

03 **Supervisor:** So the completed preparation is [2] _____, unless the fix affects it.

04 **Omar:** Correct. Flag anything that is [3] _____.

05 **Supervisor:** And the new release date is [4] _____.

06 **Omar:** Exactly. Tomorrow we review the evidence and remaining criteria, not a date we have already promised.

**CHECK THE GAPS**

**1.** temporarily paused / **2.** still usable / **3.** dependent on the repair / **4.** not yet confirmed

Why these answers fit, page 127

### Keep the boundary audible

Contrast paused with canceled. Keep the new date open until the evidence and release criteria support a decision. Do not imply that all completed work is invalid.

# 01 / Answers and explanations

## A / Read the situation

### A1. Which statement can Aiko enter as confirmed now?

**C. Six people have completed training.**

**A Not here.** The date is proposed. Aiko has not yet authorized even a conditional launch.

**B Not here.** Jordan checks staffing; the tracker assigns the decision to Aiko.

**C Correct.** The tracker confirms six completed trainees, not eight.

**D Not here.** Only two places are booked for Friday; six people are already trained.

Return to the exercise, page 4

### A2. Which next step preserves the decision boundary?

**C. Jordan checks staffing; Aiko decides afterward.**

**A Not here.** The trainees do not hold launch authority.

**B Not here.** Checking staffing does not transfer Aiko's decision right.

**C Correct.** Evidence gathering and authorization belong to different people here.

**D Not here.** That reverses the stated sequence and treats a prerequisite as a later formality.

Return to the exercise, page 4

### A3. Jordan says, "The approach is fine." Which follow-up resolves its scope?

**B. Does that include Monday, or just the sequence?**

**A Not here.** Fully aligned expands an ambiguous statement instead of clarifying it.

**B Correct.** The question separates the date from the approach without assigning a motive.

**C Not here.** That labels the statement approval before establishing whether it was approval.

**D Not here.** That assumes the date is the concern before checking what Jordan meant.

Return to the exercise, page 4

## D / Response choices

### D1. Choose a correction to minutes that wrongly say "Monday approved."

**A. Monday remains proposed; Aiko will decide after Friday's staffing check.**

**A Correct.** This corrects status, decision owner, and prerequisite together.

**B Not here.** It reverses the sequence and leaves approval ambiguous.

**C Not here.** Likelihood and silence do not provide the required authorization.

**D Not here.** It preserves the inaccurate approval status.

Return to the exercise, page 8

# 01 / Answers and explanations / continued

### D2. Which sentence distinguishes receipt from approval?

**B. I have read the plan; I have not authorized the date.**

**A Not here.** Go ahead grants the permission the sentence needs to withhold.

**B Correct.** Reading acknowledges receipt without implying permission.

**C Not here.** Accepted and in place suggest approval, not receipt alone.

**D Not here.** This explicitly makes the date final.

Return to the exercise, page 8

### D3. Two training places are booked. What can the update say?

**C. Both places are booked; completion still needs confirmation.**

**A Not here.** Availability is not supplied, and training alone does not authorize the date.

**B Not here.** Confirmed leaves readiness implied before assessment.

**C Correct.** A booking is evidence of a plan, not completion.

**D Not here.** Ready overstates what a scheduled session establishes.

Return to the exercise, page 8

### D4. Aiko wants a final check without making Jordan defend his intentions. Choose her line.

**A. What condition is missing from that summary?**

**A Correct.** It invites a factual correction without judging sincerity.

**B Not here.** It shifts a staffing condition into a judgment of commitment.

**C Not here.** It assumes Jordan agreed to the date, the disputed point.

**D Not here.** It would hide a condition that affects the record now.

Return to the exercise, page 8

## E / Conversation

### 1. reservation

**Turn 2.** A reservation limits Jordan's support; it does not withdraw support for the sequence.

### 2. provisional

**Turn 5.** Provisional keeps the date open until the staffing check and decision.

### 3. in principle

**Turn 7.** In principle expresses support for the approach without granting final approval.

# 01 / Answers and explanations / continued

### 4. authorization

**Turn 9.** Authorization is permission from Aiko, who owns the launch decision.

### 5. prerequisite

**Turn 11.** A prerequisite must be met before launch; it is not proof that all other conditions are met.

### 6. go/no-go decision

**Turn 13.** A go/no-go decision explicitly determines whether the launch proceeds.

### 7. supersede

**Turn 15.** Supersede means replace the inaccurate earlier record, not add another equally valid version.

### 8. acknowledgment

**Turn 17.** Acknowledgment of receipt confirms that Jordan received the note; it is not his launch approval.

### 9. read-back

**Turn 19.** A read-back restates the shared record so the other person can correct it.

### 10. give the green light

**Turn 20.** Give the green light means authorize the launch; this verb phrase fits after can.

Return to the conversation, page 9

## F / Repair the message

### F1. Repair the message "Twelve units approved for Tuesday."

**B. Twelve units proposed; capacity and Maya's approval are pending.**

**A Not here.** Neither a booking nor this role for Maya is supplied.

**B Correct.** The correction preserves both unresolved conditions.

**C Not here.** Acknowledging design does not grant purchasing authority.

**D Not here.** It still claims approval and treats capacity as an afterthought.

Return to the exercise, page 11

# 01 / Answers and explanations / continued

### F2. Ellis reports capacity is available. What can Maya now say?

**A. Capacity is confirmed; I will make the purchase decision.**

**A Correct.** The new fact resolves capacity, not authorization.

**B Not here.** Ellis's information does not itself authorize buying.

**C Not here.** One new fact does not change what the earlier message meant.

**D Not here.** Available capacity is not a confirmed delivery commitment.

Return to the exercise, page 11

## F / Guided speaking

### 1. proposed

**Turn 2.** Proposed is the stated status of Tuesday; the supplier has not committed to it.

### 2. capacity

**Turn 3.** Capacity is the supplier's ability to supply the twelve units, the unresolved factual condition.

### 3. approval

**Turn 5.** Maya retains the purchase decision even after capacity is confirmed.

### 4. pending

**Turn 6.** Pending means the supplier has not yet resolved the question.

Return to the conversation, page 12

## F / Second take

### 1. New fact: the supplier confirms capacity, but Maya has not approved the order. Choose Ellis's update.

**B. Capacity is confirmed; purchase approval is still pending.**

**A Not here.** The new fact does not remove her approval role.

**B Correct.** The new fact changes one status, not both. Read the sentence with stress on confirmed and pending.

**C Not here.** Capacity does not guarantee a delivery date.

**D Not here.** No order has been authorized or placed.

Return to the exercise, page 12

# 02 / Answers and explanations

## A / Read the situation

### A1. What can Mei change without requesting additional staffing?

**D. The number of pilot accounts.**

**A Not here.** Changing a label cannot establish an actual workload.

**B Not here.** Earlier evidence is not a planning variable.

**C Not here.** Additional staff need a separate approval.

**D Correct.** The case leaves the account count open within the same staffing allocation.

Return to the exercise, page 13

### A2. Which comparison needs investigation before accepting the estimate?

**D. Whether the two trials involve comparable follow-up.**

**A Not here.** Duration alone does not imply a reduction in weekly effort.

**B Not here.** The case does not establish a guarantee, and the comparison is about effort.

**C Not here.** That is an inference about intent, not a workload comparison.

**D Correct.** The previous result matters only after checking which conditions carry over.

Return to the exercise, page 13

### A3. Which statement is a personal judgment rather than a task objection?

**B. The planning team does not understand our customers.**

**A Not here.** This challenges the relationship between evidence and an assumption.

**B Correct.** It makes a broad competence judgment about people rather than identifying an estimate to test.

**C Not here.** This identifies a testable omission in the estimate.

**D Not here.** This concerns whether the proposed work fits the available capacity.

Return to the exercise, page 13

## D / Response choices

### D1. Choose a concession that does not abandon the whole pilot.

**D. The four-hour result matters; a smaller count may still work.**

**A Not here.** It commits to capacity outside Mei's stated authority.

**B Not here.** That reaches a broader conclusion than the evidence establishes.

**C Not here.** It acknowledges evidence without addressing the unsupported assumption.

**D Correct.** It accepts the evidence while keeping a narrower design open.

Return to the exercise, page 17

# 02 / Answers and explanations / continued

### D2. Chris questions the team's competence. Which response protects both people and scrutiny?

**B. Keep the criticism on the estimate; show us the missing work.**

**A Not here.** It postpones relevant scrutiny until after approval.

**B Correct.** It sets a conduct boundary and invites a substantive explanation.

**C Not here.** It suppresses the task objection in the decision meeting.

**D Not here.** It guesses intent and does not set a clear behavioral boundary.

Return to the exercise, page 17

### D3. Which conclusion is appropriately limited?

**A. A smaller pilot can test workload before any wider rollout.**

**A Correct.** Testing provides information without guaranteeing that expansion will be justified.

**B Not here.** The revised count supplies no evidence for the original time estimate.

**C Not here.** A smaller sample does not guarantee full-scale validity.

**D Not here.** Reduced scope does not eliminate measurement.

Return to the exercise, page 17

### D4. Which question invites an alternative within the stated limit?

**D. What account count can the same two managers support?**

**A Not here.** It focuses on persuasion without solving the capacity problem.

**B Not here.** It invites adjustment of an estimate to fit a preferred result.

**C Not here.** It explores extra staffing rather than an option within this limit.

**D Correct.** It holds staffing fixed while opening the negotiable account count.

Return to the exercise, page 17

## E / Conversation

### 1. premise

**Turn 2.** Premise identifies the starting assumption Chris needs to challenge specifically.

### 2. baseline

**Turn 4.** Baseline is the reference figure for comparing the new estimate with the earlier trial.

### 3. concede

**Turn 5.** Concede accepts this point while leaving the wider design open.

# 02 / Answers and explanations / continued

### 4. personal remark

**Turn 7.** Personal remark names the comment about the team's competence, not the workload objection.

### 5. feasible

**Turn 10.** Feasible means workable within the two-manager limit; it describes the alternative rather than naming a new proposal.

### 6. directional evidence

**Turn 12.** Directional evidence can indicate a pattern without supporting a firm general conclusion.

### 7. non-negotiable

**Turn 14.** Non-negotiable marks staffing as fixed for this decision, unlike the account count.

### 8. common ground

**Turn 17.** Common ground is the shared aim of useful evidence without overloading the team.

### 9. pushback

**Turn 19.** Pushback is resistance to the proposal; Mei accepts the useful challenge without endorsing the personal comment.

### 10. counterproposal

**Turn 20.** Counterproposal is the revised pilot design offered in place of the original.

Return to the conversation, page 18

## F / Repair the message

### F1. Repair "Ten customers have committed to renew."

**A. Seven have confirmed; three decisions remain open.**

**A Correct.** The correction separates established facts from possible outcomes.

**B Not here.** This unnecessarily downgrades the seven established confirmations.

**C Not here.** Unconfirmed does not mean lost.

**D Not here.** Expected does not mean committed.

Return to the exercise, page 20

# 02 / Answers and explanations / continued

### F2. Which challenge requests evidence without questioning competence?

**C. What confirmations support the other three entries?**

**A Not here.** It embeds a judgment before asking for the evidence.

**B Not here.** Changing tone would not repair the underlying status error.

**C Correct.** It asks for the missing basis of the claim.

**D Not here.** A guarantee is not a substitute for current confirmations.

Return to the exercise, page 20

## F / Guided speaking

### 1. status

**Turn 1.** Status separates confirmed renewals from pending decisions.

### 2. pending

**Turn 3.** Pending means the customers are still deciding, not that the renewals are lost.

### 3. label

**Turn 4.** Label is the field that currently misstates the renewal status.

### 4. evidence

**Turn 5.** Evidence supports the seven confirmed entries without inventing confirmations for the other three.

Return to the conversation, page 21

## F / Second take

### 1. New fact: one of the three pending customers confirms. Choose the revised forecast line.

**D. Eight renewals are confirmed; two remain pending.**

**A Not here.** It fails to incorporate the additional confirmation.

**B Not here.** Pending is not lost, and the eight are confirmed, not merely forecast.

**C Not here.** It counts the remaining two before they have confirmed.

**D Correct.** Seven plus one is eight; the remaining two decisions are still open. Keep the two statuses distinct.

Return to the exercise, page 21

# 03 / Answers and explanations

## A / Read the situation

### A1. Which action is already within Alex's authority?

**B. Move an internal check earlier in the task order.**

**A Not here.** Additional spending is reserved, with no small-purchase exception.

**B Correct.** Internal sequence changes are explicitly delegated.

**C Not here.** Customer promises require Sofia's approval.

**D Not here.** Continuation requires a review, not a team preference alone.

Return to the exercise, page 23

### A2. The team recommends a paid tool. What happens next?

**B. Alex brings the proposal to Sofia for approval.**

**A Not here.** A vote does not change who controls spending.

**B Correct.** The team may recommend; spending authority remains with Sofia.

**C Not here.** The case does not authorize this transfer of authority.

**D Not here.** Informing after purchase would bypass the retained approval right.

Return to the exercise, page 23

### A3. What does the two-week checkpoint establish?

**C. A point to review continuation, not an extension.**

**A Not here.** Silence is not the stated continuation rule.

**B Not here.** The review may choose an outcome; it is not predetermined.

**C Correct.** A checkpoint is a decision occasion, not advance permission.

**D Not here.** Oversight has not been delegated away.

Return to the exercise, page 23

## D / Response choices

### D1. Which instruction delegates clearly without disappearing?

**B. Choose the internal sequence; bring spending and promises back to me.**

**A Not here.** Full ownership is ambiguous, and proposed dates are not necessarily approved.

**B Correct.** The line gives autonomy and names the reserved decisions.

**C Not here.** Team agreement cannot replace Sofia's reserved authority.

**D Not here.** This leaves limits unstated and invites after-the-fact approval.

Return to the exercise, page 27

# 03 / Answers and explanations / continued

### D2. Alex hears "You own this." Which clarification is most useful?

**C. Does that include purchases, or just the internal sequence?**

**A Not here.** Documentation requirements do not disappear with ownership.

**B Not here.** Ownership does not imply the end of oversight.

**C Correct.** It checks an actual decision boundary rather than a vague level of trust.

**D Not here.** Trust is not a definition of authority.

Return to the exercise, page 27

### D3. Which escalation happens at the right time?

**A. The change affects a customer promise; I need approval before offering it.**

**A Correct.** It asks before creating the commitment.

**B Not here.** Waiting until review delays a required prior approval.

**C Not here.** The team does not hold that approval right.

**D Not here.** The customer would already have accepted a promise.

Return to the exercise, page 27

### D4. Choose a record that distinguishes consultation from decision.

**D. Alex gathered team input; Sofia will decide on the purchase.**

**A Not here.** Nothing in the consultation transfers authority to the vendor.

**B Not here.** Consultation does not itself grant spending authority.

**C Not here.** No silence-as-consent rule is supplied.

**D Correct.** It separates the information-gathering role from the approval role.

Return to the exercise, page 27

## E / Conversation

### 1. decision rights

**Turn 2.** Decision rights specify who may decide which kinds of changes.

### 2. within your remit

**Turn 4.** Within your remit places the internal task order inside Alex's assigned responsibility.

### 3. approval boundary

**Turn 6.** Approval boundary marks where delegated sequence choices stop and Sofia's approval is required.

# 03 / Answers and explanations / continued

### 4. use discretion

**Turn 8.** Use discretion means exercise judgment inside the delegated limits, not approve additional spending.

### 5. without approval

**Turn 10.** Without approval states the condition required before Alex can cross either delegated limit.

### 6. decision owner

**Turn 12.** Decision owner is the person who decides the internal sequence, rather than treating a vote as required authority.

### 7. keep oversight

**Turn 14.** Keep oversight means monitor the trial without personally approving every delegated choice.

### 8. requires approval

**Turn 16.** Requires approval identifies a spending or customer-promise decision that must come back before action.

### 9. decision gate

**Turn 18.** Decision gate is the checkpoint at which continuation is assessed, not pre-approved.

### 10. accountability

**Turn 20.** Accountability is Sofia's continuing obligation to answer for the trial and its oversight.

Return to the conversation, page 28

## F / Repair the message

### F1. Repair "Any inexpensive room change is approved."

**C. Existing-room changes are delegated; external bookings need Luis's approval.**

**A Not here.** No price threshold has been authorized.

**B Not here.** This removes the stated external-booking boundary.

**C Correct.** The boundary concerns booking type, not price.

**D Not here.** This reverses the boundary and invents provisional booking permission.

Return to the exercise, page 30

# 03 / Answers and explanations / continued

### F2. The team favors an external room. What can Nora report?

**C. The team recommends it; the booking is not yet authorized.**

**A Not here.** Price does not change the stated booking boundary.

**B Not here.** A future review does not supply temporary approval.

**C Correct.** A recommendation and permission remain separate.

**D Not here.** The vote does not transfer Luis's authority.

Return to the exercise, page 30

## F / Guided speaking

### 1. booking

**Turn 1.** Booking would commit to the external option, which requires Luis's approval.

### 2. authority

**Turn 3.** Authority describes the delegated right to choose between existing rooms.

### 3. recommendation

**Turn 4.** Recommendation is Nora's preferred option with its basis, not a completed reservation.

### 4. decision

**Turn 5.** Decision is the approval Luis retains for the external option.

Return to the conversation, page 31

## F / Second take

### 1. New fact: Luis approves the external room for this workshop only. Choose Nora's read-back.

**D. I may book this room for this workshop, not future sessions.**

**A Not here.** It ignores the new, specific authorization.

**B Not here.** It turns a specific approval into an unapproved price-based rule.

**C Not here.** Future events are explicitly outside this approval.

**D Correct.** The approval is specific to one event, not a general extension of authority.

Return to the exercise, page 31

# 04 / Answers and explanations

## A / Read the situation

### A1. What is available by Friday at 3 p.m. New York time?

**D. An estimate labeled provisional.**

**A Not here.** Supplier reconciliation finishes Monday morning, not Friday.

**B Not here.** The missing work is verification, not cosmetic formatting.

**C Not here.** The estimate is not confirmed and the provisional label is required.

**D Correct.** That is the supported Friday deliverable.

Return to the exercise, page 32

### A2. Which constraint can Priya change in this case?

**D. The version selected for Friday's meeting.**

**A Not here.** A preference does not make unchecked figures verified.

**B Not here.** The case requires the provisional label.

**C Not here.** She cannot make that work finish early.

**D Correct.** Priya may choose a reporting option.

Return to the exercise, page 32

### A3. Which detail prevents a cross-office deadline misunderstanding?

**B. Friday, 3 p.m., New York local time.**

**A Not here.** The sponsor's finishing time and location are not specified.

**B Correct.** The day, clock time, and location are explicit.

**C Not here.** The usual time is not supplied to every recipient.

**D Not here.** Afternoon and close of business vary by location and organization.

Return to the exercise, page 32

## D / Response choices

### D1. Choose a firm commitment Omar can support.

**D. I can send a provisional estimate Friday at 3 p.m. New York time.**

**A Not here.** Calling it final before verification misstates its status.

**B Not here.** Urgency does not remove the Monday dependency.

**C Not here.** A note does not turn an estimate into confirmed numbers.

**D Correct.** This states a feasible version and a precise delivery time.

Return to the exercise, page 36

# 04 / Answers and explanations / continued

### D2. Priya says "Just do your best." What should Omar clarify?

**A. I can commit to the estimate; verification still needs Monday's check.**

**A Correct.** The response turns effort language into a bounded deliverable.

**B Not here.** This preserves the misunderstanding rather than defining the commitment.

**C Not here.** Best effort is not authorization to bypass verification.

**D Not here.** A label cannot supply missing evidence.

Return to the exercise, page 36

### D3. Which wording preserves the caveat when figures are forwarded?

**D. Retain "provisional" on the slide and in the covering message.**

**A Not here.** Silence provides no evidence of verification.

**B Not here.** The meeting time does not resolve the Monday verification dependency.

**C Not here.** Recipients of the slide would lose the qualification.

**D Correct.** The qualification travels with the numbers in both places.

Return to the exercise, page 36

### D4. Supplier reconciliation slips. What is the responsible fallback?

**A. Send a status update and a revised verification time.**

**A Correct.** It reports the changed dependency without passing off unchecked numbers as final.

**B Not here.** The manager can still provide a timely update even if the result is delayed.

**C Not here.** This hides information recipients need to interpret the report.

**D Not here.** Meeting a deadline does not justify changing the evidence status.

Return to the exercise, page 36

## E / Conversation

### 1. Verified

**Turn 2.** Verified means checked, which cannot happen before the supplier reconciliation.

### 2. provisional

**Turn 4.** Provisional marks the figures as subject to verification rather than final.

### 3. trade-off

**Turn 6.** Trade-off describes earlier availability in exchange for figures that are not yet verified.

### 4. caveat

**Turn 8.** Caveat is the qualification that tells readers how to interpret the estimate.

# 04 / Answers and explanations / continued

### 5. deadline

**Turn 10.** Deadline is the exact delivery time, not a general effort promise.

### 6. scope

**Turn 12.** Scope is the set of work covered by this agreed version.

### 7. dependency

**Turn 14.** Dependency is work that must finish before verified figures can be supplied.

### 8. contingency

**Turn 17.** Contingency is the agreed fallback if the supplier check is delayed.

### 9. prioritize

**Turn 19.** Prioritize means choose which branch reviews should come first, not approve the final resource allocation.

### 10. acceptance criteria

**Turn 20.** Acceptance criteria specify what the agreed Friday deliverable must contain and how its status is identified.

Return to the conversation, page 37

## F / Repair the message

### F1. Repair "Reviewed translation available Friday."

**B. Translation Friday; independent review completed Monday.**

**A Not here.** The case provides no waiver of review.

**B Correct.** The wording separates translation from its later independent review.

**C Not here.** The facts permit a labeled Friday internal version.

**D Not here.** It still calls the Friday version reviewed.

Return to the exercise, page 39

### F2. Which Friday covering line preserves the limitation?

**C. Internal briefing text attached; independent review is pending.**

**A Not here.** It contradicts the stated review status.

**B Not here.** Informing the reviewer does not communicate that review is incomplete.

**C Correct.** It names the supplied text and its unresolved review status.

**D Not here.** No approval or removal of labels has been supplied.

Return to the exercise, page 39

# 04 / Answers and explanations / continued

## F / Guided speaking

### 1. review

**Turn 1.** Review is the separate quality-check stage, not the initial translation.

### 2. version

**Turn 3.** Version identifies the particular Friday text, which differs in status from Monday's reviewed text.

### 3. sign-off

**Turn 4.** Sign-off means approval, which the incomplete independent review cannot yet provide.

### 4. checkpoint

**Turn 5.** Checkpoint is the scheduled completion of independent review, not an extra translation order.

Return to the conversation, page 40

## F / Second take

### 1. New fact: the independent reviewer is delayed. Choose Nia's Monday update.

**A. Review is still pending; I will send a revised completion time.**

**A Correct.** The message keeps status accurate and provides a next step instead of relabeling unchecked work.

**B Not here.** A deadline does not complete the missing work.

**C Not here.** It hides the limitation and misstates the earlier version.

**D Not here.** Delivery does not waive the review.

Return to the exercise, page 40

# 05 / Answers and explanations

## A / Read the situation

### A1. Which issue is easy to miss in the current discussion?

**C. Arun's unaddressed routing concern in chat.**

**A Not here.** Leila owns the decision but has not made it.

**B Not here.** No removal of the check is supplied.

**C Correct.** The concern is present but has not been heard or answered.

**D Not here.** The schedule is prepared; routing is the unresolved condition.

Return to the exercise, page 42

### A2. What prevents the team from treating the queue as ready?

**D. The routing check is not complete.**

**A Not here.** Time pressure affects the discussion but does not itself establish readiness.

**B Not here.** Preparation of one workstream is not a reason to stop; it also cannot resolve routing.

**C Not here.** The communication channel does not make the concern less valid.

**D Correct.** The case makes that check a go-live condition.

Return to the exercise, page 42

### A3. Who should state the go-live decision after the evidence is reviewed?

**C. Leila, the named decision owner.**

**A Not here.** Providing technical evidence does not transfer Leila's authority.

**B Not here.** Owning a prepared schedule is not launch authority.

**C Correct.** The case retains that decision with Leila.

**D Not here.** Speaking order and silence do not determine decision rights.

Return to the exercise, page 42

## D / Response choices

### D1. Ben interrupts Arun. Choose an intervention that protects both turns.

**C. Arun, finish the routing point. Ben, you are next.**

**A Not here.** This rewards the interruption and removes the remote speaker from the decision discussion.

**B Not here.** This preserves the crosstalk that prevents people from hearing.

**C Correct.** It protects the current speaker while specifying a later turn for Ben.

**D Not here.** Having a chat message is not the same as hearing and resolving its point.

Return to the exercise, page 46

# 05 / Answers and explanations / continued

### D2. Which paraphrase preserves Arun's concern?

**B. Routing is unverified; a ready schedule does not settle it.**

**A Not here.** This removes the before-go-live requirement.

**B Correct.** It keeps the routing condition distinct from staffing readiness.

**C Not here.** It changes an unverified condition into readiness and invents a motive.

**D Not here.** Unverified does not mean rejected or canceled.

Return to the exercise, page 46

### D3. The discussion drifts to slide design. Which line parks it responsibly?

**A. Ben, bring the slide choice Thursday; routing comes first now.**

**A Correct.** It assigns the deferred issue a return point while protecting the current priority.

**B Not here.** This prioritizes presentation over a prerequisite.

**C Not here.** No owner or return point prevents the item from disappearing.

**D Not here.** This dismisses the issue rather than deferring it with ownership.

Return to the exercise, page 46

### D4. Which closing record is accurate before the routing result arrives?

**D. Checks assigned; go-live not yet authorized.**

**A Not here.** It approves before the required check.

**B Not here.** The schedule is ready and has not been rejected.

**C Not here.** Silence cannot replace the check or Leila's decision.

**D Correct.** Assigning checks is progress, but it is not approval.

Return to the exercise, page 46

## E / Conversation

### 1. crosstalk

**Turn 4.** Crosstalk is overlapping speech that prevents the remote contribution from being heard.

### 2. unverified

**Turn 5.** Unverified means not yet checked; it does not assert that a fault has been found.

### 3. paraphrase

**Turn 6.** Paraphrase restates Arun's meaning while inviting correction.

### 4. timebox

**Turn 9.** Timebox means set a limit on this discussion, not waive a required check.

# 05 / Answers and explanations / continued

### 5. parking lot

**Turn 11.** Parking lot means a deferred discussion list, not a decision to discard the issue.

### 6. action item

**Turn 15.** Action item is the specific check with an owner and reporting time.

### 7. decision is pending

**Turn 17.** Decision is pending states that preparation is complete in one area but launch authorization has not been given.

### 8. decision log

**Turn 19.** Decision log preserves what was and was not decided, including Arun's actual concern.

### 9. unresolved question

**Turn 19.** Unresolved question invites missing information without treating silence as authorization.

### 10. recap the next steps

**Turn 20.** Recap the next steps is a verb phrase meaning summarize the actions, without presenting them as a launch decision.

Return to the conversation, page 47

## F / Repair the message

### F1. Repair "Ines wants to delay the demonstration."

**C. Ines reports an unfinished Spanish-label check.**

**A Not here.** The line dismisses the check without evidence.

**B Not here.** Neither rejection nor a new-deck request is supplied.

**C Correct.** It records her actual information without inferring her preference.

**D Not here.** It reverses the status and invents a preference.

Return to the exercise, page 49

### F2. Which chairing line gives the missed concern a fair hearing?

**C. Ines, explain the unchecked labels; Pavel, respond after her.**

**A Not here.** Understanding is assumed although the concern has not been heard.

**B Not here.** It authorizes release before considering the unresolved check.

**C Correct.** It makes space for evidence and preserves a turn for Pavel.

**D Not here.** It delays relevant information until after the decision.

Return to the exercise, page 49

# 05 / Answers and explanations / continued

## F / Guided speaking

### 1. floor

**Turn 1.** The floor is the right to speak without being cut off at this point in the meeting.

### 2. unchecked

**Turn 2.** Unchecked means their quality has not been verified; it does not assert that they are wrong.

### 3. pending

**Turn 4.** Pending preserves Noah's decision until the check has been considered.

### 4. recap

**Turn 6.** Recap summarizes the evidence and decision without turning one into the other.

Return to the conversation, page 50

## F / Second take

### 1. New fact: Ines finds no label errors, but Noah has not decided on release. Choose Pavel's update.

**A. The label check is complete; release awaits Noah's decision.**

**A Correct.** The check supplies evidence; the decision remains separate.

**B Not here.** The decision right remains with Noah.

**C Not here.** Ines owns the check, not the release decision.

**D Not here.** This confuses evidence completion with the later decision.

Return to the exercise, page 50

# 06 / Answers and explanations

## A / Read the situation

### A1. Which opening is supported by the record?

**B. Both reports arrived after the Thursday-noon deadline.**

**A Not here.** There is a dependency, but cause and negligence are not established.

**B Correct.** The arrival and due times are observed facts.

**C Not here.** His priorities and choices have not been established.

**D Not here.** No changed deadline is supplied.

Return to the exercise, page 51

### A2. Which consequence can Elena describe without adding facts?

**B. Planning deferred its staffing update.**

**A Not here.** This is a coaching discussion, not a supplied disciplinary procedure.

**B Correct.** That is the stated effect of the late reports.

**C Not here.** No warning or response has yet been established.

**D Not here.** No lost contract is reported.

Return to the exercise, page 51

### A3. Which question investigates the missing information?

**D. What happened between the source-file handoff and delivery?**

**A Not here.** The work has a real dependency that cannot be removed by a promise.

**B Not here.** It pressures Diego to endorse an unestablished judgment.

**C Not here.** It assumes intentional disregard.

**D Correct.** It asks about the process without deciding the cause first.

Return to the exercise, page 51

## D / Response choices

### D1. Choose feedback that separates observation from interpretation.

**A. The report arrived Friday; I need to understand the delay.**

**A Correct.** It states what happened and asks about the cause.

**B Not here.** The second clause presents an inferred attitude as fact.

**C Not here.** The record alone does not establish that the deadline was impossible.

**D Not here.** It establishes blame before investigating the handoff.

Return to the exercise, page 55

# 06 / Answers and explanations / continued

### D2. Which agreement is measurable without pretending Diego controls the source team?

**D. Flag a missing file Wednesday at three; send a Thursday-noon status update.**

**A Not here.** This repeats the silent delay rather than creating an early warning.

**B Not here.** The expectation lacks an observable trigger and reporting time.

**C Not here.** Diego cannot guarantee another team's action or all future figures.

**D Correct.** Both are actions Diego can take even if the input remains missing.

Return to the exercise, page 55

### D3. Diego explains a late source file. Which response maintains the standard and investigates cause?

**A. That helps explain the delay; let's fix the handoff and warning point.**

**A Correct.** It acknowledges the explanation while changing the process.

**B Not here.** It dismisses a relevant dependency instead of examining it.

**C Not here.** One explanation does not justify abandoning the reporting standard.

**D Not here.** The dependency does not remove Diego's communication responsibility.

Return to the exercise, page 55

### D4. Which closing checks action rather than demanding reassurance?

**A. At next Thursday's check-in, we will review the file and update times.**

**A Correct.** It specifies what evidence will be reviewed and when.

**B Not here.** It asks for an attitude claim rather than observable follow-through.

**C Not here.** An unlimited promise is not a practical review measure.

**D Not here.** It predetermines blame rather than reviewing what happened.

Return to the exercise, page 55

## E / Conversation

### 1. impact

**Turn 3.** Impact describes the effect on planning, not an accusation about Diego's intentions.

### 2. upstream input

**Turn 5.** Upstream input is the source file supplied by another team before Diego can complete his work.

### 3. early-warning signal

**Turn 7.** Early-warning signal is notice that the deadline is at risk before it passes.

# 06 / Answers and explanations / continued

### 4. bottleneck

**Turn 9.** Bottleneck is the handoff that is restricting timely report completion in this account.

### 5. performance expectation

**Turn 11.** Performance expectation here includes timely communication, not a guarantee over another team's input.

### 6. action plan

**Turn 14.** Action plan names specific steps and times instead of a general promise to improve.

### 7. update

**Turn 14.** Update is the timely communication Diego can send even if the underlying file is still missing.

### 8. rework

**Turn 17.** Rework is duplicated effort caused by inconsistent updates or changed information.

### 9. recurrence

**Turn 19.** Recurrence means the same late, unannounced handoff pattern happening again.

### 10. follow-through

**Turn 20.** Follow-through means carrying out the agreed warning, update, and review actions.

Return to the conversation, page 56

## F / Repair the message

### F1. Repair "You keep ignoring customers."

**C. Both callbacks happened Wednesday, after the Tuesday commitment.**

**A Not here.** The case does not support a customer misunderstanding.

**B Not here.** The cause is not established.

**C Correct.** It replaces a motive claim with the observed timing pattern.

**D Not here.** That promises control over a dependency Jo does not necessarily have.

Return to the exercise, page 58

# 06 / Answers and explanations / continued

### F2. Which request creates an observable early warning?

**C. If the answer is missing at three, send a status message then.**

**A Not here.** A missing answer does not silently cancel a customer commitment.

**B Not here.** That preserves the silence causing delayed customer updates.

**C Correct.** It gives an explicit trigger and an action Jo can perform.

**D Not here.** Jo cannot guarantee the arrival of every technical answer.

Return to the exercise, page 58

## F / Guided speaking

### 1. bottleneck

**Turn 1.** Bottleneck asks about the process constraint without presuming a motive.

### 2. warning

**Turn 2.** Warning would have alerted the customer before the promised callback was missed.

### 3. status update

**Turn 3.** Status update communicates what is known and what remains missing without pretending the answer is complete.

### 4. check-in

**Turn 5.** Check-in is the agreed later review of observable actions, not a guarantee that all answers arrive on time.

Return to the conversation, page 59

## F / Second take

### 1. New fact: Jo sends the three-o'clock warning, but the technical answer arrives Wednesday. Choose Sal's feedback.

**B. The warning was on time; the technical dependency still needs attention.**

**A Not here.** The new fact explicitly says Jo sent the warning.

**B Correct.** It recognizes the completed communication action without declaring the whole issue solved.

**C Not here.** It collapses two separate measures.

**D Not here.** A timely warning does not mean the original callback commitment was met.

Return to the exercise, page 59

# 07 / Answers and explanations

## A / Read the situation

### A1. What does Ren need the information to support?

**B. Early warning of service failures.**

**A Not here.** This motive is not established by the reporting request.

**B Correct.** That is the stated purpose, not a preference for a second archive.

**C Not here.** The brief explicitly distinguishes early warning from a second archive.

**D Not here.** Separate mandatory reports are outside this process change.

Return to the exercise, page 61

### A2. Which proposed change falls within the supplied authority?

**A. Agree a new format for this internal service update.**

**A Correct.** Both offices may agree the format and cadence of this process.

**B Not here.** Removing duplicate entry does not remove monitoring.

**C Not here.** Separate mandatory reporting cannot be changed here.

**D Not here.** Missing information and an established failure are different.

Return to the exercise, page 61

### A3. Which fact best explains the branch's workload concern?

**D. Re-entering the figures takes one hour per day.**

**A Not here.** Most are already in the dashboard.

**B Not here.** No such general permission is supplied.

**C Not here.** Distrust is not established.

**D Correct.** It quantifies the effort without judging headquarters' motives.

Return to the exercise, page 61

## D / Response choices

### D1. Which opening translates the disagreement into a shared problem?

**C. What decision needs an alert, and which figures support it?**

**A Not here.** It assumes an emotional motive and invites defensiveness.

**B Not here.** It frames the issue as attitude rather than information needs.

**C Correct.** It asks about purpose and evidence before changing the method.

**D Not here.** It exceeds the authority and ignores fields or needs the dashboard may not cover.

Return to the exercise, page 65

# 07 / Answers and explanations / continued

### D2. Which description makes exception reporting operational?

**C. Monitor routinely; alert Ren when the agreed trigger is met.**

**A Not here.** Missing information requires clarification, not automatic reclassification.

**B Not here.** Frequency and trigger are left undefined.

**C Correct.** It preserves monitoring and names an explicit alert condition.

**D Not here.** It substitutes reactive discovery for early warning.

Return to the exercise, page 65

### D3. Which sentence protects the scope of the process change?

**A. This changes the internal update, not any separate mandatory report.**

**A Correct.** It states what the agreement does not authorize.

**B Not here.** Overlap alone does not authorize ending mandatory reports.

**C Not here.** An audit trail remains useful even without duplicate entry.

**D Not here.** Owning data does not transfer every decision right.

Return to the exercise, page 65

### D4. Ren worries about losing visibility. Which reply addresses that concern?

**A. Keep dashboard access and agree an alert owner and response time.**

**A Correct.** It preserves access and defines how exceptions will reach someone.

**B Not here.** Silence may reflect a missed alert or delayed refresh.

**C Not here.** An ownership gap would weaken early warning.

**D Not here.** A monthly delay may defeat the stated early-warning purpose.

Return to the exercise, page 65

## E / Conversation

### 1. duplicate entry

**Turn 2.** Duplicate entry is retyping information that already exists in the shared record.

### 2. information requirement

**Turn 4.** Information requirement identifies what Ren needs to know for a particular decision.

### 3. exception reporting

**Turn 6.** Exception reporting sends alerts for defined deviations while routine monitoring continues.

# 07 / Answers and explanations / continued

### 4. threshold

**Turn 8.** Threshold is the agreed trigger for an alert, rather than an unspecified feeling that something is wrong.

### 5. acknowledgment time

**Turn 10.** Acknowledgment time sets when the recipient confirms receipt, without pretending the issue is already resolved.

### 6. refresh cycle

**Turn 12.** Refresh cycle describes when the dashboard's information is updated.

### 7. single source of truth

**Turn 14.** Single source of truth is the agreed authoritative record for these figures, not a promise that data is infallible.

### 8. audit trail

**Turn 16.** Audit trail records the correction and supporting history rather than silently overwriting the earlier figure.

### 9. reporting cadence

**Turn 18.** Reporting cadence is the frequency of routine updates, distinct from immediate exception alerts.

### 10. escalation path

**Turn 20.** Escalation path states where an unacknowledged or unresolved alert should go next.

Return to the conversation, page 66

## F / Repair the message

### F1. Repair "No slides means no more reporting."

**D. Routine monitoring continues; alerts replace duplicate slide entry.**

**A Not here.** This removes early detection of the missed target.

**B Not here.** Separate required reports are unchanged.

**C Not here.** An absent alert is not proof of a positive result.

**D Correct.** It changes the communication method, not the responsibility to monitor.

Return to the exercise, page 68

# 07 / Answers and explanations / continued

### F2. Which process detail is needed before the change starts?

**A. The alert trigger, sender, recipient, and response expectation.**

**A Correct.** These make the alert route usable and testable.

**B Not here.** That permission is outside the supplied authority.

**C Not here.** An assumption is not an agreed monitoring or alert arrangement.

**D Not here.** Presentation styling does not establish how warnings will be handled.

Return to the exercise, page 68

## F / Guided speaking

### 1. authoritative record

**Turn 1.** Authoritative record is the agreed source for the counts, not a second slide total.

### 2. trigger

**Turn 2.** Trigger is the defined missed-service-target condition that requires notice.

### 3. receipt

**Turn 3.** Receipt acknowledges the alert has arrived; it does not mean the service issue is resolved.

### 4. unchanged

**Turn 5.** Unchanged preserves the boundary of this internal process revision.

Return to the conversation, page 69

## F / Second take

### 1. New fact: an alert is sent, but neither Lin nor the deputy acknowledges it within the agreed time. Choose Rae's next step.

**B. Use the agreed escalation route and preserve the alert record.**

**A Not here.** That loses the record and delays the early-warning process.

**B Correct.** The missing acknowledgment activates the escalation arrangement, not an assumption that someone acted.

**C Not here.** No reply does not waive ongoing monitoring.

**D Not here.** Delivery is not acknowledgment or resolution.

Return to the exercise, page 69

# 08 / Answers and explanations

## A / Read the situation

### A1. What must the corrected record preserve?

**D. Lena raised a customer risk, not a timing preference.**

**A Not here.** The risk remains unresolved.

**B Not here.** A repair does not predetermine the business outcome.

**C Not here.** Neither approval nor a meeting-time preference is supplied.

**D Correct.** The minutes mischaracterized the nature of her concern.

Return to the exercise, page 70

### A2. Which action is Daniel in a position to promise?

**A. Correct the minutes and give the concern a full hearing.**

**A Correct.** These are concrete process repairs within his role.

**B Not here.** That would predetermine a decision before reviewing the risk.

**C Not here.** A communication repair cannot establish that outcome.

**D Not here.** He cannot control Lena's feelings or timetable for trust.

Return to the exercise, page 70

### A3. Which statement acknowledges an action rather than disputing its impact?

**D. I interrupted you twice and left your risk explanation unfinished.**

**A Not here.** Equal responsibility is not established by the case.

**B Not here.** It supplies a justification rather than acknowledging the harm.

**C Not here.** It conditions the apology on her interpretation and centers his intent.

**D Correct.** It owns a specific observable action.

Return to the exercise, page 70

## D / Response choices

### D1. Choose the strongest opening repair.

**A. I cut you off twice, and I recorded your concern incorrectly.**

**A Correct.** It names the actor, behavior, and record error without demanding reassurance.

**B Not here.** The qualification turns the apology into a defense and invents a constraint.

**C Not here.** It makes the harm conditional and assigns agency to the format.

**D Not here.** It centers her feeling and his intention rather than owning the action.

Return to the exercise, page 74

# 08 / Answers and explanations / continued

### D2. Which correction addresses the original audience?

**C. Send the corrected risk description to the same meeting group.**

**A Not here.** A schedule does not correct the mischaracterized concern.

**B Not here.** It diffuses responsibility and leaves the specific false record intact.

**C Correct.** The people who received the inaccurate description need the correction.

**D Not here.** The public misunderstanding remains even if the relationship improves privately.

Return to the exercise, page 74

### D3. Lena is not ready to reassure Daniel. Which response respects that?

**B. You do not need to settle this now; I will make the correction today.**

**A Not here.** It makes factual correction depend on emotional resolution.

**B Correct.** It allows time while committing to a concrete repair.

**C Not here.** The second clause contradicts the permission by demanding reassurance.

**D Not here.** It declares the impact resolved on Daniel's timetable.

Return to the exercise, page 74

### D4. Which promise protects a fair process without fixing the outcome?

**D. I will hear the risk fully before we make the project decision.**

**A Not here.** It trades a business outcome for reassurance before review.

**B Not here.** It erases relevant information rather than repairing its treatment.

**C Not here.** The case says it remains unresolved.

**D Correct.** It promises consideration, not approval.

Return to the exercise, page 74

## E / Conversation

### 1. mischaracterized

**Turn 3.** Mischaracterized names the inaccurate description of Lena's concern, not merely a difference in tone.

### 2. acknowledge

**Turn 5.** Acknowledge explicitly recognizes the reported impact without disputing Lena's experience.

### 3. circulate

**Turn 7.** Circulate means send the corrected wording to the meeting group, rather than merely acknowledge it privately.

# 08 / Answers and explanations / continued

### 4. ownership

**Turn 9.** Ownership means accepting responsibility for the interruption and inaccurate record.

### 5. process commitment

**Turn 11.** Process commitment promises a fair hearing, not a predetermined business outcome.

### 6. working agreement

**Turn 13.** Working agreement states how the next discussion will be conducted and how meaning will be checked.

### 7. intent

**Turn 15.** Intent is what Daniel meant to achieve; he distinguishes it from what actually happened.

### 8. follow-up

**Turn 17.** Follow-up is a later check on whether the promised repair actually happened.

### 9. a full hearing

**Turn 19.** A full hearing gives Lena time to explain the evidence without interruption; it does not promise approval.

### 10. trust

**Turn 20.** Trust is confidence supported by later actions, not something an apology can require immediately.

Return to the conversation, page 75

## F / Repair the message

### F1. Repair "I am sorry if you wanted more attention."

**C. I omitted your analysis from the credits; I will correct that today.**

**A Not here.** The proposed remedy is outside Mara's stated authority.

**B Not here.** The assumed audience knowledge does not correct the record.

**C Correct.** It owns the omission and promises a relevant repair.

**D Not here.** This explains away the omission rather than repairing it.

Return to the exercise, page 77

# 08 / Answers and explanations / continued

### F2. Which follow-up repairs the specific record?

**B. Send executives the revised credits before they forward the update.**

**A Not here.** It does not repair Chen's missing credit in this update.

**B Correct.** The correction reaches the recipients of the original omission in time.

**C Not here.** The result is accurate; only attribution needs correction.

**D Not here.** This shifts responsibility for Mara's omission onto Chen.

Return to the exercise, page 77

## F / Guided speaking

### 1. attribution

**Turn 1.** Attribution identifies who contributed the analysis; it is the part of the update that needs repair.

### 2. correction

**Turn 3.** Correction adds the missing credit to the existing record.

### 3. omission

**Turn 5.** Omission is the information missing from the credits, not an error in the numerical result.

### 4. revised record

**Turn 6.** Revised record is the corrected update that should carry the accurate contribution forward.

Return to the conversation, page 78

## F / Second take

### 1. New fact: the credits are corrected, but Chen remains upset. Choose Mara's response.

**D. The correction is done; you do not need to reassure me now.**

**A Not here.** It asks him to erase the original omission.

**B Not here.** It adds an outcome Mara cannot promise.

**C Not here.** Mara cannot decide that Chen's frustration has ended.

**D Correct.** It separates an observable repair from the other person's timetable for trust.

Return to the exercise, page 78

# Review 1 / Explanations

## Cumulative review

### 1. Which label belongs on Thursday?

**C. Proposed; reviewer readiness and authorization are still open.**

**A Not here.** Pending confirmations do not establish cancellation.

**B Not here.** Support for an approach does not authorize the date.

**C Correct.** Neither support for the approach nor a booking grants final approval.

**D Not here.** A pending booking is not a confirmed reviewer.

Return to the exercise, page 22

### 2. Which question tests the criticism instead of guessing a motive?

**D. Which workload assumption needs different evidence?**

**A Not here.** It suppresses useful scrutiny.

**B Not here.** It infers resistance and assumes the sponsor selected a direction.

**C Not here.** Tone cannot establish staffing capacity.

**D Correct.** It focuses the challenge on a testable premise.

Return to the exercise, page 22

### 3. Choose the accurate distinction.

**C. Acknowledgment records understanding; authorization permits action.**

**A Not here.** Receipt or understanding is not necessarily approval.

**B Not here.** This reverses the functions.

**C Correct.** These functions should not be merged in a decision record.

**D Not here.** Neither definition captures the actual function.

Return to the exercise, page 22

### 4. Which response accepts scrutiny and sets a boundary?

**C. Test the capacity estimate; leave judgments about the team out.**

**A Not here.** It turns a task objection into a loyalty judgment.

**B Not here.** It suppresses the substantive problem along with the personal one.

**C Correct.** It preserves criticism of the plan while limiting personal judgments.

**D Not here.** It approves before testing and redirects criticism toward people.

Return to the exercise, page 22

# Review 2 / Explanations

## Cumulative review

### 1. Which action can Eva take now?

**B. Reorder the internal presentation without buying external design.**

**A Not here.** That creates a commitment before required approval.

**B Correct.** Sequence changes are delegated; spending is not.

**C Not here.** Team support is not Malik's approval.

**D Not here.** A future estimate provides no current spending authority.

Return to the exercise, page 41

### 2. Which Friday message is accurate?

**B. Design recommended; cost estimate provisional; purchase approval pending.**

**A Not here.** A provisional review is explicitly possible.

**B Correct.** It distinguishes recommendation, evidence status, and authorization.

**C Not here.** None of these final statuses is supplied.

**D Not here.** It implies an unauthorized purchase and delayed approval.

Return to the exercise, page 41

### 3. The sponsor asks for a "final" Friday estimate. Choose the reply.

**C. Friday can be provisional; the check finishes Monday.**

**A Not here.** Changing labels cannot supply verification.

**B Not here.** Hiding a pending check does not make the estimate final.

**C Correct.** The version can be clarified without promising an impossible check.

**D Not here.** Recommendation and approval are separate.

Return to the exercise, page 41

### 4. Which item belongs in the written commitment?

**B. Version, delivery time, time zone, and pending dependency.**

**A Not here.** These do not resolve delivery or decision boundaries.

**B Correct.** These details define what is promised and what still limits it.

**C Not here.** Hope and assumed approval leave key commitments ungrounded.

**D Not here.** Best-effort language without boundaries preserves ambiguity.

Return to the exercise, page 41

# Review 3 / Explanations

## Cumulative review

### 1. Which chairing action comes first?

**D. Give Ava an uninterrupted turn to explain the missing file.**

**A Not here.** The missing file affects the work being discussed.

**B Not here.** That pressures her to accept the inaccurate interpretation.

**C Not here.** No such agreement rule is supplied, and the message raised a concern.

**D Correct.** The missed contribution needs to be heard before its meaning is summarized.

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### 2. Which wording separates observation from cause?

**B. Two reports arrived late; we need to trace the handoff.**

**A Not here.** It assigns a motive without evidence.

**B Correct.** It states the observed pattern and investigates the explanation.

**C Not here.** Late arrival does not prove the deadline changed.

**D Not here.** That cause has not been established for both incidents.

Return to the exercise, page 60

### 3. Choose the most useful early-warning agreement.

**B. If the file is missing at the agreed checkpoint, send a status update.**

**A Not here.** Ava cannot guarantee another team's outcome.

**B Correct.** The trigger and action can be observed even when the input is outside Ava's control.

**C Not here.** Dependencies do not cancel commitments without communication.

**D Not here.** That preserves silence while others depend on an update.

Return to the exercise, page 60

### 4. Which correction belongs in the minutes?

**A. Ava reported a missing input; the cause of past delays remains under review.**

**A Correct.** It corrects her concern and preserves uncertainty about the earlier incidents.

**B Not here.** It retains the mischaracterization and overstates cause.

**C Not here.** Nothing establishes withdrawal or resolution.

**D Not here.** Neither approval nor removal of the dependency is supplied.

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# Review 4 / Explanations

## Cumulative review

### 1. Which correction accurately states the proposal?

**A. Retain monitoring; replace duplicate slides with defined alerts.**

**A Correct.** The method changes, not the obligation to monitor.

**B Not here.** Mandatory reports remain unchanged.

**C Not here.** Silence is not verification and alerts are part of the proposal.

**D Not here.** That is not the proposed process.

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### 2. Which apology owns the specific error?

**A. I interrupted you and recorded your proposal incorrectly.**

**A Correct.** It identifies the behavior and record error without a conditional apology.

**B Not here.** It shifts the focus to the analyst's clarity.

**C Not here.** It gives the dashboard responsibility for a human interruption and summary.

**D Not here.** It justifies the behavior and implies an unsupported attitude problem.

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### 3. Which agreement must precede the alert trial?

**B. Define triggers, owners, acknowledgment times, and an escalation route.**

**A Not here.** A conduct repair does not authorize changing unrelated requirements.

**B Correct.** These make the new process explicit and accountable.

**C Not here.** Assumptions cannot replace operational checks.

**D Not here.** Repairing an interaction does not approve a business proposal.

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### 4. Which promise repairs the process without predetermining the result?

**C. Correct the record and review the proposal on its actual merits.**

**A Not here.** It makes a fair hearing conditional on reassurance.

**B Not here.** It exchanges the outcome for reassurance before review.

**C Correct.** It restores a fair hearing without promising approval.

**D Not here.** It preserves the false account received by others.

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# Additional case 1 / Explanations

## Extended conversation

### 1. reprioritize

**Turn 2.** Reprioritize means change the order of importance when available capacity cannot cover everything.

### 2. first pass

**Turn 8.** A first pass is an initial review, not the complete analysis requested originally.

### 3. trade-off

**Turn 12.** Trade-off names the competing benefits and costs of choosing one priority over another.

### 4. sign-off

**Turn 16.** Sign-off means explicit approval of this revised priority and delivery plan.

### 5. reopen

**Turn 18.** Reopen means return to a decision for further discussion rather than silently adding more work.

### 6. point of contact

**Turn 20.** Point of contact identifies the person who will receive questions and coordinate follow-up.

Return to the conversation, page 80

## Transfer exchange

### 1. outside the agreed scope

**Turn 1.** The third group was not in the approved two-group Friday first pass.

### 2. within the same capacity

**Turn 3.** The case says replacing a group fits; adding a third does not.

### 3. subject to a new decision

**Turn 4.** A future scope change needs a fresh priority decision rather than silent addition.

### 4. separate from the full analysis

**Turn 5.** The reduced Friday deliverable does not include the unscoped regional breakdown.

Return to the conversation, page 82

# Additional case 2 / Explanations

## Extended conversation

### 1. take credit

**Turn 4.** Take credit means accept recognition for work or an achievement, including work done by others.

### 2. follow-up

**Turn 7.** A follow-up is a later message or action that addresses an earlier exchange.

### 3. spotlight

**Turn 12.** Spotlight means concentrated public attention; here it could make an employee uncomfortable.

### 4. attribution

**Turn 15.** Attribution identifies who produced particular work rather than crediting only the manager.

### 5. omission

**Turn 18.** Omission means something left out; here it is the contributors' names and work.

### 6. routine

**Turn 20.** Routine means an established repeated practice, not a one-time response to this incident.

Return to the conversation, page 83

## Transfer exchange

### 1. accurate as reported

**Turn 1.** The case says the results are correct; the problem is missing credit.

### 2. incomplete as written

**Turn 3.** The three contributors and their roles were omitted.

### 3. explicitly attributed

**Turn 4.** Explicitly attributed identifies who did which work rather than merely thanking an unspecified team.

### 4. needed before circulation

**Turn 5.** The sponsor has not yet forwarded the results, so the corrected credits should travel with them.

Return to the conversation, page 85

# Additional case 3 / Explanations

## Extended conversation

### 1. hold off

**Turn 2.** Hold off means postpone an action temporarily while a relevant concern is resolved.

### 2. narrow down

**Turn 8.** Narrow down means reduce the possible causes or options through further investigation.

### 3. decision point

**Turn 12.** Decision point identifies the choice that must be made now, rather than every later question.

### 4. invalidate

**Turn 15.** Invalidate means make something no longer valid; the failed test does not cancel all completed work.

### 5. release criteria

**Turn 18.** Release criteria are the conditions that must be met before the launch can proceed.

### 6. make the call

**Turn 20.** Make the call means make the decision after reviewing the relevant information.

Return to the conversation, page 86

## Transfer exchange

### 1. temporarily paused

**Turn 2.** The failed test postpones release; it does not abandon all launch work.

### 2. still usable

**Turn 3.** Completed work remains valid unless the eventual fix changes it.

### 3. dependent on the repair

**Turn 4.** A dependency needs review when the technical repair is understood.

### 4. not yet confirmed

**Turn 5.** The next date depends on unresolved repair work and release checks.

Return to the conversation, page 88

# Find a phrase by purpose

## Check meaning before assuming agreement

**Specify the reference:** When you say "fine," are you referring to the date or the overall approach?

**Separate two meanings:** I heard support for the approach, not approval of the date.

**State the condition:** My support is conditional on having eight trained people.

Full phrase bank, page 7

## Challenge ideas respectfully

**Ask for the premise:** Which assumption are you challenging?

**Request evidence:** What are you basing that estimate on?

**Concede one point:** I accept the capacity concern; I do not accept that the whole pilot is unworkable.

Full phrase bank, page 16

## Make authority and participation clear

**Invite a recommendation:** Bring me your preferred option and the reason for it.

**Delegate clearly:** You may change the internal sequence without seeking approval each time.

**Reserve a decision:** Customer commitments remain my decision.

Full phrase bank, page 26

## Negotiate realistic commitments

**Identify the purpose:** What decision does the Friday meeting need to make?

**Offer alternatives:** We can provide an estimate on Friday or verified figures on Monday.

**Make a conditional offer:** We can meet Friday if the deliverable is an explicitly provisional estimate.

Full phrase bank, page 35

# Find a phrase by purpose / continued

## Include every voice in a meeting

**Stop overlap:** One voice at a time, please; the remote line cannot distinguish us.

**Protect a turn:** Arun has not finished. I will come to you next, Ben.

**Enter the discussion:** May I come in on the routing point before we move on?

Full phrase bank, page 45

## Give specific, useful feedback

**Name the occasion:** For each of the last two weekly reports, we agreed on Thursday noon.

**Describe the behavior:** Both reports arrived on Friday morning.

**Explain impact:** Planning had to defer its staffing update while it waited for the figures.

Full phrase bank, page 54

## Coordinate across offices

**Ask about use:** Which decision does each daily figure support?

**Quantify the burden:** Re-entering the eighteen figures takes one hour each day.

**Preserve the purpose:** I want to reduce duplication, not reduce your visibility.

Full phrase bank, page 64

## Repair misunderstandings and build trust

**Own the action:** I interrupted you twice and summarized your concern inaccurately.

**Apologize directly:** I am sorry I cut you off.

**Acknowledge the effect:** You did not get a fair chance to explain the customer risk.

Full phrase bank, page 73

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# References and publication notes

All cases, organizations, figures, and conversations are fictional teaching material, not transcripts. Communication practice does not replace qualified advice or current workplace procedures. References checked 14 October 2026.


### [1] Council of Europe. Common European Framework of Reference for Languages: Mediation.

Background for collaborative meaning-making and communication across linguistic or cultural barriers. The lesson cases and the B2-C1 study range are editorial choices, not Council of Europe endorsements.

https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/mediation

### [2] Center for Creative Leadership. Use SBI (Situation-Behavior-Impact) to Inquire About Intent.

The Situation-Behavior-Impact framework is attributed to the Center for Creative Leadership. Lesson 6 practices a related distinction between observed behavior, effect, and unverified assumptions about motive; its dialogue is original.

https://www.ccl.org/articles/leading-effectively-articles/closing-the-gap-between-intent-vs-impact-sbii/

### [3] Edmondson, Amy. 1999. Psychological Safety and Learning Behavior in Work Teams. Administrative Science Quarterly 44(2): 350-383. DOI: 10.2307/2666999.

Background on interpersonal risk and team learning. This study does not establish national personality types or imply that effective teams never disagree.

https://dash.harvard.edu/entities/publication/13a7b031-0fdd-45ec-a7e0-2b80e2bc679f


> **Companion course**
>
> The website offers the eight-lesson course and related practice. This book can be used independently. No audio access or external account is needed for its exercises.
>
> https://englishladder.com/efsp-cultural-leadership-us-branches.html

# Speak clearly. Keep the relationship.

A strong leader can question an estimate, correct a record, refuse an unsupported promise, and still leave room for the other person to contribute. The language in this book makes those choices explicit.

### Name the claim

Ask which assumption or piece of evidence is being challenged.

### Keep the distinction

Separate understanding from approval, a target from a commitment, and a concern from a confirmed fault.

### Close the loop

Name the action, the owner, the deadline, and the next decision.

### Repair the record

Correct the same audience that received the mistake; do not require immediate reassurance.

---

## Phil Stilwell

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